

This free document contains the first chapter of The Book of BEM: Gamification beyond gamification

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Foreword: an introduction to BEM	3
CHAPTER I: THE DISCIPLINE AND THE DISCIPLE	7
From a Tool to a Discipline	9
Gamification as a Multidisciplinary Design Discipline	10
The 3 Paradigms of the School of BEM	12
BEM: a motivation-driven design framework	14
The Language of BEM for Dynamic Systems	17
Incentives: The Forces That Shape Systems and Users	17
Goals: drive direction and anticipation	19
Deferred Goals: What People Mistakenly Call Rewards	21
Main, Micro and Secondary goals: the real cherry on top of the pie	23
Action vs State Goals: behaviors and strategies	26
Relative goalposts: making competition fun	27
Cycle and Chained goals for building loops	29
Feedback: Interaction and emotion	29
The discriminatory coherent signal	31
Feedback Information for emotional contagion	33
Feedback as attention re-capturers	34
Multi-signal feedback: reinforcement and divergence	35
Feedback and the algorithms of evaluation	36
Immediate or delayed? Not a simple answer	36
Feedback to manage failure	37
The notification: unexpected feedback systems	38
Rewards: not something you can give	39
The PBL elephant in the room	39
From anticipation to reality	40
A new old language for rewards	41
Intrinsic or Extrinsic? It's not about the rewards	42
Introjection, Integration and Regulation	42
There is nothing forbidden in design	44
Finally, the GFR Framework	46
The 7 BEM Intrinsic Drivers	47
Hedonism & Aesthetic Pleasure	49
Efficiency & Economic Productivity	50
Relatedness & Empathy	52
Mastery & Progress	54
Discovery & Creativity	55
Empowerment & Control	56

Epic Identity & Purpose	57
From Drivers to Designable Archetypes	60
Hedonism	61
Efficiency	61
Mastery	62
Relatedness	62
Discovery	62
Empowerment	63
Epic Identity	63
Applying Archetypes in the Design Process	64
You are now Disciple of BEM	66

Foreword: an introduction to BEM

The world of Arkadia is built upon strong feelings. Warriors, speedsters, ninjas, and all sorts of heroes inhabit its 8-bit realm. Their lives are awful, full of death, horrible puzzles, and high stakes. But watching their every move, a manipulative god pulls their strings, impervious to their suffering. In the language of Ok, that god is called the PLYR.

The Book of BEM explores my findings from working in gamification and serious games. For the last 10 years, I have been polishing a framework built upon one premise: games are not tools for behavior manipulation through the use of meaningless rewards. This simple premise led me to try to understand how to create meaningful gamification platforms that rely on other aspects of game design. Applying this perspective has been fruitful. I have tested my framework across diverse projects, from Learning and Development to Loyalty, and I have found that, again and again, understanding gamification in a meaningful way requires understanding the relationship between the player, the context, and the system.

A systemic approach to gamification requires recognizing that games are built on complexity, with multiple relationships between elements, concepts, meanings, moving parts, and rules. This includes not only the rule system of the gamification project, but also the rules of the culture you are trying to influence and the rules of the processes you are intervening in. It means understanding effects not only in the short term, but also being able to anticipate long-term systemic artifacts, emergent relationships that will grow over time as the player evolves and learns.

And worse still, the most unpredictable part of the system is the human element. We are dealing with immense complexity, as each player brings different agendas, pains, fantasies, and cognitive frameworks. Of course, game design as a discipline helps reduce uncertainty through accumulated experience about how players react to mechanics, and motivation research can explain many of the behaviors you might observe. Nevertheless, having a myriad of human minds interacting with the same system can produce all kinds of consequences.

We design for the player, but not innocently. Players enter your system for their own reasons, to satisfy their own needs, but the game has its own agenda, the agenda of the designers. There is a great deal of egotism embedded in a gamification project's KPIs, since the drive for motivation or behavior change is usually tied to business goals. The system is inherently asymmetrical. The game is not charitable; it is born with a purpose. Aligning the mission of designers and stakeholders with the objectives of players is not an easy task.

This asymmetry explains the prevalence of heavy, reward-reliant designs. For many designers, the tension is resolved through a kind of trade: we give you something you like

if you give us the behaviors we want. When you ask, “How can I motivate my users?”, you are implying that you want to apply an external force to make them act in a certain way. You know it is an expensive approach, but surely the right rewards can fix everything, right? Creating reward cycles to drive behavior is not the exclusive domain of good game design. You are merely disguising a centuries-old paradigm with terminology borrowed from games, such as experience points, levels, or badges, and calling it a game.

It is an easy confusion to make. Games use reward cycles, but game designers borrow from everywhere to construct experiences: blockchain, traffic control, agriculture, socialism, civilization growth, economics, biology, and more. Games did not invent points, progress bars, badges, avatars, storytelling, missions, challenges, levels, wars, or markets. Games are not built upon elements; they are built upon rules and experience design. Everything else consists of tools that designers use to construct those rules and experiences.

Think of it this way: play is intrinsic to every mammal, and it is both ritual and structure. Watch two cats playing. Their posture changes to signal that they are in a playful state. The game becomes a dance, but the ritual has limits. They cannot truly harm each other. Human play is more complex but stems from the same principles. Observe two children playing. They negotiate the ritual and establish rules to ensure the game unfolds properly. Those rules grow more complex as they age, as they recognize that poor play behavior can damage the group’s experience, and that additional constraints can make the game more interesting. Humans continuously optimize and patch rules to enhance the social experience while preserving conflict, the resistance that makes each game unpredictable. Game designers are simply children who have taken this principle to another level. We study player interactions and formulate hypotheses about how to create better conflict without damaging the experience. The tension between conflict and positive emotional outcomes, between rules and experience, is what truly makes a game.

In this process, games have adopted point systems, economic principles, recognition tokens, progression rules, and more, crafting rule sets that optimize experience. Consider the level-up mechanic. Human progression through skill development or ascension of power is embedded in daily life: military hierarchies, training in tools and weapons, mastery of skills. That is not play; that is living. Yet sports and games formalized these principles into rule systems that make certain experiences compelling. Look at the leveling system in tabletop role-playing games. Heroes require progression mechanics to unlock new skills, and that training must represent accumulated experience. Thus, experience points emerged. Then designers optimized the mechanic by awarding XP for defeating enemies or solving problems, assigning values according to difficulty, and establishing thresholds that unlock new abilities. These systems accelerate progression compared to real life, because real life unfolds slowly.

Gamification, then, is not about extracting elements from games and placing them into serious contexts. It is about identifying game structures, or schemas, and applying their design principles to improve real-world systems. Reward cycles are not new, and they introduce well-known problems. When you attach points to behaviors and layer

redemption mechanics on top, you create farming dynamics, which in game design are notorious for diminishing experiential quality. Should you avoid rewards entirely? No. You may use them. But as with any design decision, the rules must be optimized so that the focus of the system is not the reward itself, but the experience created by interacting with the rules.

How, then, can we resolve the asymmetry between designers' agendas and players' desires without resorting to reward-centric systems? That is what BEM attempts to address. I have been working to resolve this design conflict without relying on low-hanging mechanics rooted in extrinsic manipulation, tools that game designers are not trained to use as their primary strategy.

This book aims to offer a more rigorous way to approach gamification projects, always through the lens of game design. I do not claim to have all the answers. But perhaps you will find insights that prompt you to reconsider the problem from a different perspective. Perhaps it will spark conversation. Perhaps it will help you develop a more analytical framework for identifying strong and weak designs in a field that continues to expand every day.

It is time to take your game designer's guitar out of its case and begin to play.

PART I: THE DISCIPLINE AND THE DISCIPLE

Ragaard, the curious, felt like a Campbellian hero standing before the doorway he was about to cross. Once he stepped into that room, The Alchemist would close it until he could master her secrets. She had a piercing gaze and a static semblance, as if inquiring whether her new disciple would be able to understand the Discipline. Raagard hesitated for a second, then crossed into the chamber, and the door was closed. He would not be able to unsee the mysteries to come.

The unfinished story of Ragaard, from the recovered scripts of Balice.

I did my first gamification project in 2013. It was my first attempt to bring the gamification concepts I had been learning about into a real-life system. I had consumed a great deal of content by Gabe Zicherman and had completed Werbach's Coursera course. I thought I had found the holy grail, the bridge between my love for games and game design and a concrete methodology for changing the world. I was not a game designer yet, even though Jesse Schell had written in my copy of *The Art of Game Design* that I was one, on the first page no less. That book remains one of my real treasures. My only practical experience was a card game I published called *Xanadú*, which had some success with reviewers and players, but emerged from a purely empirical attempt at designing a game.

That first attempt was a project for a consultancy company. They wanted to create a gamified platform that would capture data on their clients, data they could later analyze using their human development model. So I worked with everything I had learned so far. I knew it was about applying game thinking in a serious context, and I assumed players would love clear reward cycles based on digital goods, access, power, and status. The project had no real success and never saw the light of day.

I followed the whole process. I defined mechanics for achievers, explorers, and socializers, and we deliberately excluded killers. We had avatars, badges, leveling mechanics, the whole package. But the system was not engaging. The core elements of the design were of no interest to the intended players. You learn from failure, right? Well, not always immediately.

My next project was a Groupon-like initiative. It was a platform that offered users discounts if they shared their coupons on Facebook or Twitter. They called it "Social Pay." Again, it was based on daily missions and mystery boxes that awarded coins redeemable for special promotions. It included a contextual leaderboard and clear schedule mechanics. But most players never reached level two. The bounce rate was terrible, and although gamification helped the entrepreneur sell the platform to vendors and investors, the user engagement numbers were disappointing.

I had several more experiences like that, until I almost gave up on the entire concept. My conclusion at the time was that game elements were not enough to create engagement, and rewards were not as appreciated as I had assumed. That was when I decided to discuss this with my sister. Ana María completed her PhD at Concordia University in Human Development and has extensive experience researching human motivation. We discussed the topic at length, and still do, since she later became a partner in both of my gaming companies. She shared academic papers with me so I could better understand what was happening in my designs. Her first advice was to be cautious about extrinsic rewards and heteronomous design, in which I was attempting to control users' behaviors.

Coincidentally, around that time Scott Nicholson, a former board game reviewer, began studying gamification and published a YouTube video and academic work on Meaningful Gamification. This led me to Sebastian Detering's research on the same concept. I then discovered Yukai Chou's Octalysis framework and Andrzej Marczewski's Hexad. Everything pointed in the same direction: Self-Determination Theory.

Following my sister's advice, I read work by Edward Deci and his colleague Richard Ryan. I immersed myself in theories of psychological needs and the distinction between intrinsic and extrinsic motivation. I immediately noticed that Richard Bartle's player types closely resembled the core drivers of Self-Determination Theory: autonomy reflected in explorers, mastery in achievers and killers, and relatedness in socializers. I began to see connections everywhere between game design theory and intrinsic motivation research. This period consumed me. Everything I read pointed to the same conclusion: reward-centered designs were undermining the joy of the systems I was creating.

I began integrating these ideas into new projects. For example, I worked on motivating a salesforce team in a large company and incorporated a rudimentary application of the Octalysis framework to clarify the types of mechanics I wanted to implement. The results improved considerably. Still, problems emerged. The salesforce was, like most corporate teams, driven by incentives, and I observed players cheating the system, sometimes in surprisingly cooperative ways.

So I continued studying, exploring fields such as Behavioral Economics. I had read Dan Ariely's *Predictably Irrational* in 2012, so the field was not entirely new to me, but I had never examined it deeply. I was familiar with cognitive biases and how people make irrational decisions depending on how choices are framed, but I had not yet connected these insights to game design. The concept of a "nudge," for example, did not enter my conceptual framework until 2016.

Researching across disciplines to explain design artifacts and principles fundamentally changed my understanding of gamification.

From a Tool to a Discipline

Before becoming the OGREBANE, Johans was a young smith learning to wield a sword. After each battle he survived, he would return to his master and tend to his blade. Galdor would tell him, "Never forget that the sword is only a tool, but swordsmanship is a discipline. You must study the sword, but only to understand your art. Your sword, your body, and your mind are one part of the battlefield. Your surroundings and your enemy must also be studied. Never forget that."

Journals of the Grand Warrior of Callon, the tale of the OGREBANE.

Working with my sister often made me feel like her disciple. Each new paper she shared and each discussion we had helped consolidate design principles that had previously been obscure to me, and forced me to rethink assumptions I had taken for granted.

I began to see that many approaches labeled as gamification were not truly about gamification. Early consultants, for example, pointed to LinkedIn's progress bar for profile completion as a form of gamification. I was not convinced. It seemed to me more like a Behavioral Economics intervention, and a very effective one, but not something that required knowledge of game design. Similar examples were drawn from platforms such as eBay or Kickstarter. If a system included a progress bar, it was labeled gamification. Other initiatives, such as the piano staircase experiment, came closer to my understanding. There was playfulness, as in many behavioral experiments, but it lacked a truly gameful structure. To me, the piano staircase was more of a toy than a game, and I questioned its long-term engagement potential.

I now believe these cases were categorized as gamification for three reasons. First, there was a need for visible success stories. Second, the definition of gamification was ambiguous. Third, and most importantly, gamification was treated as a design tool. It was seen as an add-on that could be seamlessly incorporated into any project. As a result, gamification was reduced to a toolkit of widgets and components, and progress bars became part of that supposed toolkit. Over time, I came to see this as a deeply flawed way of thinking, although at first I struggled to articulate why.

In 2014, I began teaching in an Industrial Design program at a university. They invited me because of my work with games and my background in literature, which they believed could enrich their curriculum. I always found the combination somewhat unusual, but the opportunity was transformative. I spent nearly three years teaching courses to young industrial designers and mentoring them on their graduation projects. Through this experience, I realized something essential about gamification. If I wanted to truly develop its potential, I had to stop thinking of it as a tool and start thinking of it as a discipline.

There is no formal game design major in Colombia, but there are other design disciplines, and they share an important characteristic. They are not about prescribing fixed methodological steps. They are about cultivating paradigms of thought. Each graduation project began with similar foundations, understanding the object, the context, and the user, yet each was resolved through different resources and theoretical approaches. Multiple schools of thought coexist within the same discipline, often disagreeing with one another. What unites them is a shared object of study and a body of research that grounds the profession. A design discipline teaches you how to perceive a problem through a structured corpus of paradigms that guide solution-making. That is what gamification should be.

With that conviction, I decided to build my own school of gamification, grounded in the body of research I had studied. I needed foundational paradigms and a framework capable of articulating my findings. That is how I began developing BEM.

Gamification as a Multidisciplinary Design Discipline

“Remember that you’ll never understand the magic of Dain if you don’t study the sciences of fluids and the void.”

-Grand Mage Agatheia

Each discipline attempts to define its scope, to establish limits around what it is and what it is not. Those borders are usually gray, but they revolve around a central object of study. Gamification is a design discipline, and every design discipline begins from the same foundation: its object of study is the relationship between the user, the designed artifact, and the context.

Artistic disciplines share a similar scope, since they also involve creative processes. Consider literature, which is my original field of study. The corpus of thought in literature is organized in layers. First, there are theories that explore the fundamental principles of narrative creation, such as Campbell’s hero’s journey. Then there are reception theories, which examine how readers construct meaning from those narrative structures. Finally, there are discourse theories, which analyze how narratives explain or even shape social processes, such as theories related to colonialism.

From there, the discipline borrows theories, concepts, and ideas from adjacent fields. Every literature student reads philosophy and history. These neighboring bodies of knowledge enrich the intellectual framework and expand interpretative possibilities, allowing connections that reveal otherwise overlooked phenomena. Gamification must similarly determine which theoretical corpus belongs to its core problem, and which bodies of knowledge are adjacent yet necessary.

Following this rationale, I realized that gamification cannot be reduced to a catchy definition. A simplified definition may be useful for communicating with a client, but for a disciple of gamification it would be equivalent to defining graphic design as the use of graphic elements on paper or digital media to improve message readability. That description is not wrong, but it excludes much of what a graphic designer actually does. As a discipline, gamification must be grounded in principles and theories, and significant progress has already been made in that direction.

First, there is the object of study. Gamification is analogous to game design in that it studies game theory and design principles to create engaging systems. The primary distinction is that these principles are applied to products, services, and processes that exist outside a bounded game environment. From this perspective, the core principles of gamification should originate in **game design theory**. This interpretation gives coherence to the term game-ification and places into perspective other definitions that emphasize behavioral psychology or behavioral economics. From this standpoint, consultants who never study games to understand what makes them function may be practicing behavioral science, and that is valid. It can work. They may use points and badges effectively. But that is not gamification as a design discipline.

However, we must also understand the user and the context. Here, **theories of human motivation and system complexity** become essential. A disciple of gamification studies these theories through the lens of the game designer, seeking to understand how such principles operate within games to generate engagement and meaningful experience, while also anticipating systemic emergent effects within real-world contexts. The ability to predict how players will act and feel, and how the surrounding culture and system will respond, is central to the discipline.

I now believe this forms the core of gamification studies: the triadic relationship between the player's motivations and reactions, the game-like system introduced, and the pre-existing real-world system into which it is embedded. From this foundation, one may explore secondary or adjacent theories that support the design process, such as Design Thinking, Agile methodologies, or other product and service design frameworks.

You may question the precision of what I am proposing here, and that is entirely appropriate. A healthy discipline allows itself to be studied, debated, and reshaped. You may develop another school of thought, and that would enrich the field. What matters is remembering that *gamification is a design discipline*. Treating it as such allows you to give it form and depth. Once we move beyond a convenient definition, we must ground the discipline in paradigms. Those paradigms give coherence to the practice and meaning to the craft.

The 3 Paradigms of the School of BEM

The movement of the stars is a mystery. Some say they are fixed to an invisible veil that revolves around Arkadia, but I know they are projections of light emerging from the core of our planet. It is our core that moves, yet we cannot feel it.

- Studies of Ellen of Eltar, on the core of Arkadia, Book III

It was clear to me what my first paradigm would be: avoid reward-centric designs. My motto became simple. If you *need* extrinsic rewards, your system is not well designed. You may *want or choose* to use them, but you should not *depend* on them.

I wanted to build a framework centered on intrinsic drivers, emphasizing that games are *autotelic* activities. They are enjoyable for their own sake and because of how they are constructed. Gamification designs should preserve their “voluntary” nature as much as possible and players should engage because they are interacting with an interesting system. Rewards should be a well-thought small part of a grander design, and not just any reward would suffice. Later, I will revisit and challenge the very concept of *rewards*, but for now, let us place a pin in that discussion.

From there, I tried to elaborate further on this paradigm by thinking about what those rewards were meant to achieve: behavior change. In this sense, I understood that each gamification design should seek to fulfill certain key behavioral indicators (KBIs), and that the whole idea of using gamification in a project was to reduce the uncertainty around possible human actions. Player behaviors should be, to some extent, predictable, or at least limited.

This is easier to achieve in a fully fledged game with a closed system, but we should be able to accomplish it to a degree in the open system of the real world. Here I thought it should not be about operant conditioning techniques, but rather about behavioral economics experiments. Around this definition, I created the **first BEM paradigm**: the **B** stands for *Behavior Prediction, Exploration and Constraint*, and it was built on the concept of using informational cues to lead people down the right path. I will discuss this further on.

My **second paradigm** was built around another issue: gamification designs sometimes felt like casino games to me. They seemed like big Skinner boxes filled with calls to action and carrots. It was, in fact, the same issue, but seen from another angle. When a player is heavily immersed in these cycles, she may develop a feeling of addiction. Of course, people confuse addiction, compulsion, and obsession, but nevertheless the word addictive was appearing frequently in the gaming world, even as a marketing mechanism to draw players into freemium games. Oh, the freemium industry!

I had a strange realization around that time. In 2014, I created my gamification consultancy and named it *Free to Play*. I had wanted to call it *Level Up*, but that name was already taken. At the time, most of Zicherman's cohort used freemium game mechanics as examples of engagement techniques, so I thought the name was clever. But later I realized that games like Farmville had a peculiar secondary effect. After playing for more than a year, a player who left the game often described a feeling of liberation, of being free from the *work* she was doing *for* the game. I did not want a school of gamification based on that feeling. I wanted something closer to the AAA industry, where games are built to *optimize* experience, not monetization tricks. Of course, this practice has now permeated the biggest studios, like EA, but let's try to avoid learning from their overuse of microtransactions, loot boxes and an overuse of DLCs

I understood then that I did not want my future disciples, if I ever had any, designing *black hat* systems. That made me reconsider frameworks like Octalysis, that opened too much space for that possibility. It was not that I wanted to avoid concepts like property or scarcity altogether, it was that I did not want to rely excessively on engagement tricks, often mislabeled as mechanics, instead of systemic design. The real question became this: how would my players leave my system? Would they feel it was a great experience, or would they think, "Finally, I managed to leave this game"?

So once again, I wanted to avoid manipulation techniques and focus on *experience* and *emotional outcomes* that would emerge from the rule sets. And thus, the **E** appeared. Each project must be an amazing *experience*, and every mechanic and feedback element should be designed to produce the right *emotional* outcomes. This is a heavy burden to bear, but it has allowed me to think about my designs within a more demanding framework. In the end, what you get are engaged and grateful players who appreciate the effort behind the design.

My **final paradigm** was built on the concept put forward by Detering and developed by Nicholson: the system should be *Meaningful* for the players. The **M** was a no-brainer, but understanding what it meant within the framework was crucial. Both Nicholson and Detering started from human development theories like Self-Determination Theory to create meaning for the player. The core idea was that a player should leave the system a better person than when they entered. That meant rejecting the classic engagement loop of *call-to-actions->behaviors->feedback*, in favor of a more comprehensive learning cycle.

Motivation theories were central to the design process, as in other frameworks, but for me it was about more than that! Working with industrial designers on physical and digital interfaces taught me something important: it was about managing *complexity*, *information*, and *difficulty*. The idea behind the M is not just to teach, but to improve the learning curve and reduce the stress of exposing the player to new information.

Here I thought about game design principles, such as Miyamoto's four stages of level design, used to introduce mechanics without relying on explicit tutorials. There are many

similar theories and design patterns for onboarding, scaffolding and guiding players toward mastery. This was a key insight for me, especially because I knew that, for example, one of the main issues in board game design is writing instruction manuals that help players get through the tedious process of learning rules. If I wanted to foster cultural change or teach new skills, I needed to think of the game as a *growth* cycle, where each loop or iteration focused on improving and playing with different skills. Feedback and information updates were not just engagement mechanisms. They were central to the learning cycle and had to be designed with care.

And BEM was born. This behavioral, experiential, meaningful approach keeps me grounded in my designs, especially when low-hanging fruit is tempting. It has also kept me engaged over the years. Each project is novel and cannot be solved with a template. That was the core of treating gamification as a discipline.

BEM: a motivation-driven design framework

“I felt the urge, the forbidden diamond of Gelden staring back at me. I knew I was going to be tempted, but why was it so hard to contain myself? I almost touched it, but I knew the curse could be even worse. This diamond could be my last. So I turned back and exited the vault, empty-handed but alive.”

The declaration of Osmon, The Burglar, on the case of the missing Diamond of Gelden.

The word motivation is full of baggage. Motivational books promise happiness and fulfillment that will push people to achieve their goals. On the other hand, to motivate someone can mean offering a punishment or a reward for an activity they might not do for pleasure alone. But, what will we understand by this burdened concept?

Motivation comes from *motus*, or *movement*, but more in the sense of a *motor* or engine. Motivation can be measured through observing behaviors, but behavior is movement, not the engine. Why do behaviors arise? That is what we are trying to understand! That is the engine.

Causal explanations are rarely simple. “Why did you miss work today?” “Because I had to take my little brother to school.” Behind that answer, there is more than meets the eye. Why not leave your brother at home? Why not ask for an Uber ride? Many additional questions could be asked, but, in the end, behaviors arise from a combination of external and internal pressures.

“My dad would have killed me!” This engine of behavior was driven, or conducted, by fear of something external. External pressures come in the form of triggers, calls to action, and informational cues that drive behavior. Toothpaste companies started broadcasting commercials at 8 p.m. every day to cue you to brush your teeth, and you probably use

alarms as reminders or to wake yourself up. All these external signals can have a significant influence on your behavior and decision making.

But every choice and behavior you perform also takes into account psychogenic factors, internal pressures that can modify your response to those external cues. On the one hand, reacting to the dad's possible demands is disempowering, which might create resistance toward the behavior: "Why should I do what he wants me to do?" On the other hand, relatedness kicks in, and our hypothetical son might feel the need to keep his relationship with his dad in good standing. And then we have emotions! Fear can drive many behaviors, because it builds around the possibility of receiving a painful consequence if you make the wrong choice. But there is also fatherly love, which might push him to do extraordinary things for him. All of these internal pressures build toward a decision in a matter of microseconds, eventually *driving* one course of action over another.

Now, not every choice is shaped by strong internal or external pressures. Some cognitive biases are called "unmotivated" because we react in the same way regardless of our motivational state. If I ask you to calculate $5 + 2$, your brain will likely fill in the answer without reflecting on whether you actually *wanted* to solve it. Our brain can perform quick decisions through heuristics, rules of thumb that allow us to respond rapidly. And some behaviors are not triggered by salient external cues at all. Maybe you simply felt like taking your guitar out and starting to play because you were bored. But understanding this anatomy of behavior helps us identify the factors that influence our decisions, and this is highly relevant for gameplay!

Games are external systems that pressure behaviors, such as avoiding an incoming bullet or moving a piece on a board because it is your turn. But you engage with those systems because of internal drives, such as the need for discovery, mastery, or connection. The rules of the game are there to make you act, but they do so in a way that allows you to resolve inner needs that real life may not always satisfy. Game designers have progressively learned how to activate the right triggers so that you willingly spend energy within the system while leaving with a sense of accomplishment and satisfaction.

However, we do motivation a disservice if we do not look at the *actual* definition used in psychology:

Motivation is the process that initiates, guides and maintains goal-oriented behaviors.

This definition condenses what you might find in a meta-analysis on the subject and highlights the core components we need to consider:

1. Motivation can't exist without **goals**. Without goals there is no motivation, and game designers are, in a way, goal designers.
2. Motivation requires **attraction** to initiate behavior. Something must draw you in and start the process.

3. Motivation requires constant **feedback**, so the behaviors and intentions can be adjusted and guided.
4. Motivation requires engagement **loops** that maintain behavior over time.

So how can we measure motivation? A behavioral psychologist will tell you that you can only measure observable actions or physiological reactions and infer the rest. If you observe behavior within context and understand how to connect the dots, you can form a reasonable explanation of why a behavior emerged. But beyond direct behavior, we can also examine three additional dimensions.

Arousal: refers to energy expenditure. Some behaviors involve low energy thresholds, such as playing video games, which require almost no physical effort, while others require much more, such as playing sports. If you choose higher energy activities, you are demonstrating greater motivation. Furthermore, if you invest more energy than the minimum required, you are demonstrating even stronger motivation. Going the extra mile, pushing beyond what is necessary, or avoiding the bare minimum are all signals of heightened arousal.

Persistence: refers to how long you sustain effort over time. Some activities demand repeated energy investment, such as going to the gym. When actions must be repeated consistently, people may give up sooner if motivation is low. If an activity produces negative emotional or physiological consequences, it becomes harder to persist. Going to the gym is difficult because it strains your muscles and demands attention to repetitive, effortful tasks. Many people stop after a few days. At the same time, repetition without progression can kill enjoyment and create the sense that there is no longer any challenge in an activity that once felt rewarding.

Direction: refers to where motivation is oriented. When you are not motivated, you feel **apathetic** or lack a meaningful trigger to act, which is normal, since your brain filters out many goals that are irrelevant to you (thank god!). But motivation operates in two possible directions: **approach** or **avoidance**. If you are pursuing a goal, you are operating under approach motivation. If you are actively trying to avoid something unpleasant, you are also motivated and expending energy to remove pain. This can be understood in terms of pains and desires, two distinct psychological drivers that must be addressed differently.

I believe all three dimensions are essential in Gamification design. You must regulate energy expenditure and keep it within a flow state. You must manage persistence by reducing unnecessary resistance to continued engagement. And you must address players' pains and desires to help them make appropriate choices. This is not simple, but if you understand basic human drives and impulses, and if you know the building blocks you have at your disposal, you can design systems that work with these principles rather than against them.

Part II: The Building Blocks

“Magic is a matter of alchemic combinations of essential ingredients and words, spelled and integrated in the correct order. If the right words are uttered under the right conditions, worlds will emerge and wonder will ensue.”

Extract from Magica Principia, by the Archmage of Illusium

The disciplinary approach to gamification requires building the core design principles of the framework. Each framework should have some basic rules of thumb that help guide the design process, while establishing a dialogue with the existing literature on the topic.

The BEM framework is game-design centered, which means its core elements stem from game design paradigms applied to non-game contexts. For many practitioners, this has meant including what are often called “game elements” in serious environments. BEM takes a different path. It focuses on understanding the building blocks of game design and incorporating them in more substantial ways.

BEM understands games as uncertainty machines ruled by interaction mechanisms. Interactivity means developing a language for two-way communication through interfaces. If the core language of game design is properly understood, it can be translated into more serious designs without turning everything into a “game.” A shift in how interactivity is structured can make products and services more game-like without superficial layering.

This chapter will explore that core language in depth as a way of identifying the building blocks of a gamified system.

The Language of BEM for Dynamic Systems

“If the goal is to enrage the wylm, sending troops to the Fearia borders is the way to go. Another option is surrounding the forests of Ealindal, but the elves do not treat trespassers lightly. I would recommend the pass of Tro and facing the bandits with shields and bows.”

Last council of the army of Drakados, before its defeat by ambush in the Rikanian Wars

Managing behaviors, experience, and meaning through motivational design requires a **language**, a structure that helps shape the three goals of BEM. Gamification is about building interactive systems based on game-like structures, so we need to understand the basic building blocks that shape the core of the framework. Curiously enough, I came to

fully understand these building blocks only after years of working with gamification. They quickly became core to this Discipline: they are goals, feedback, and rewards, or GFR.

Conditionals—“if this, then that”—are the foundational language of any dynamic system and the way GFR cycles are structured. Whether in games, education, business, or human behavior, conditional structures define how systems react to inputs, adapt to player interactions, and create meaningful engagement. From these conditionals emerge user and system objectives, feedback mechanisms, and the neurological triggers that drive motivation. Understanding how to design these elements effectively is key to crafting systems that feel organic, motivating, and satisfying.

Every game, every learning platform, and every workplace incentive structure operates through conditionals. In *Super Mario Bros.*, if Mario touches a coin, then he earns coin points. If he reaches 100 coins, then he earns an extra life. In a fitness app, if you complete 10,000 steps, then you unlock a badge. These structures create clear cause-and-effect relationships, giving users predictable and understandable interactions. The designer’s task is to construct conditionals that resonate with intrinsic motivations, ensuring that actions feel meaningful rather than mechanical, while also understanding how those conditionals will shape how the system behaves and evolves over time.

Conditionals in dynamic and interactive systems are not merely linear instructions: they can evolve into intricate networks of dependencies that shape the user experience. In *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*, multiple layers of conditionals operate simultaneously. If the player finds a torch, then they can carry fire. If they combine fire with a wooden weapon, then they create a makeshift flaming sword. These cascading conditionals empower players to explore and experiment, generating a sense of agency and discovery that makes the system feel alive. If...then... structures shape the game world as well as the player’s choices. And that is why we can design, in a tangible way, structures of incentives.

Incentives: The Forces That Shape Systems and Users

“Lady Lana of Rhin is a better teacher. Of course, I have always been inclined to be near beautiful women, but it’s more than that. I truly believe she can read the nature of the human heart, discern the thoughts of kings, and uncover the hidden clues that shape history. But her class was uphill after a 30-minute walk, so I took history with Mr. Finch instead.”

Rikan’s Head of Council, on his time at the Gigan’s University

Incentives are all the elements within a system that can drive decision making in a particular direction. Goals and feedback are two of the most prominent forms of incentives, but they are not the only ones. Rules, environmental design, and overall experience also play a crucial role in shaping user behavior. Every choice you make as a designer will have an impact on the user’s motivations.

Rules, for example, act as structural incentives that define the boundaries of a system. In chess, movement restrictions guide strategic thinking. In a productivity app, constraints on when and how tasks can be completed influence user efficiency. Experience, on the other hand, creates emotional incentives. Consider how the atmosphere of a luxurious store encourages customers to behave differently than they would in a casual marketplace. In a fast food restaurant, if the chairs are comfortable, customers might stay longer and be willing to spend more. If they are not, customers may leave quickly, making room for new ones. These are design decisions shaping behavior through incentives.

Humans have been using incentives for millennia, but studying them systematically for only a couple of centuries. From operant conditioning to loyalty programs to architectural design, we have tested countless combinations of conditionals to try to predict behavior and systemic change. Over time, the emphasis has shifted. At first, attention was placed on the consequences of achieving a goal. Later, focus moved toward redesigning environments. Then toward changing procedures and the rules of systems themselves. The study of incentives has been driven by our desire to feel control over dynamic systems. Yet when humans are part of the equation, we rarely get it right. Human behavior introduces chaos.

In chaotic systems, even slight variations in initial conditions can produce wildly different outcomes, sometimes to the point of true unpredictability. By incorporating incentives, the aim is to reduce uncertainty and constrain the evolution of our designs. But we often miss the mark, mainly because the effects of incentives on humans are **highly counterintuitive**.

Many novice gamification designers fail because they fail to grasp this complexity. PBLs, the infamous points, badges, and leaderboards, are often designed under the mistaken assumption that game elements themselves drive motivation, as if points or badges had a secret power to make people *want* them. In response, other designers tend to badmouth PBLs altogether, claiming that points and badges are bad practice. They argue that people are not moved by them as once believed, shouting “Stop doing that!”.

Both positions miss the point. PBLs are not incentives in themselves, but the conditionals built behind them. How and why do you earn points? What happens if you accumulate enough of them? What if you are too slow to earn them? What if you never reach the threshold required for your goal? What if the activity that grants points is fundamentally boring? What if the leaderboard constantly reminds you that you cannot win? What if... These are the real questions.

Incentives modify choice, but you can't just take choice away, at least not without creating an authoritarian system that destroys experience and meaning. Designing gamified incentives is about making certain choices more appealing than others, and ensuring they remain appealing over time. This is far more complex than it sounds, and simply bribing users with arbitrary benefits is not the way to go.

That is why we need to understand the foundations of the GFR model. Only then we'll be able to design incentives that follow best practices and avoid the traps of purely extrinsic systems. What comes next will cover the rules of goal and feedback design to improve the chances of creating better incentives.

Goals: drive direction and anticipation

"Everybody asked me why I did it. What did I expect to achieve? Treasure, men, fame, power? None of that. Killing the General, my best friend, was necessary, or he would have discovered that I leaked his war plan to the High Council. I just wanted to keep my head."

Confession of the Great Vizier of Kha'an, moments before his beheading

Game designers are, among other things, expert goal designers. Designing goals seems easy, but most people are not really suited for it. Ask yourself: "Where do you see yourself in five years? What do you want to accomplish by next summer? What are your goals for this week?" Chances are you do not have a clear answer, or your answer is based on external goals, the ones given to you by your peers, your family, your friends, or even your culture. And even if you are able to define a goal, you will probably struggle with how to track it and measure progress toward achievement.

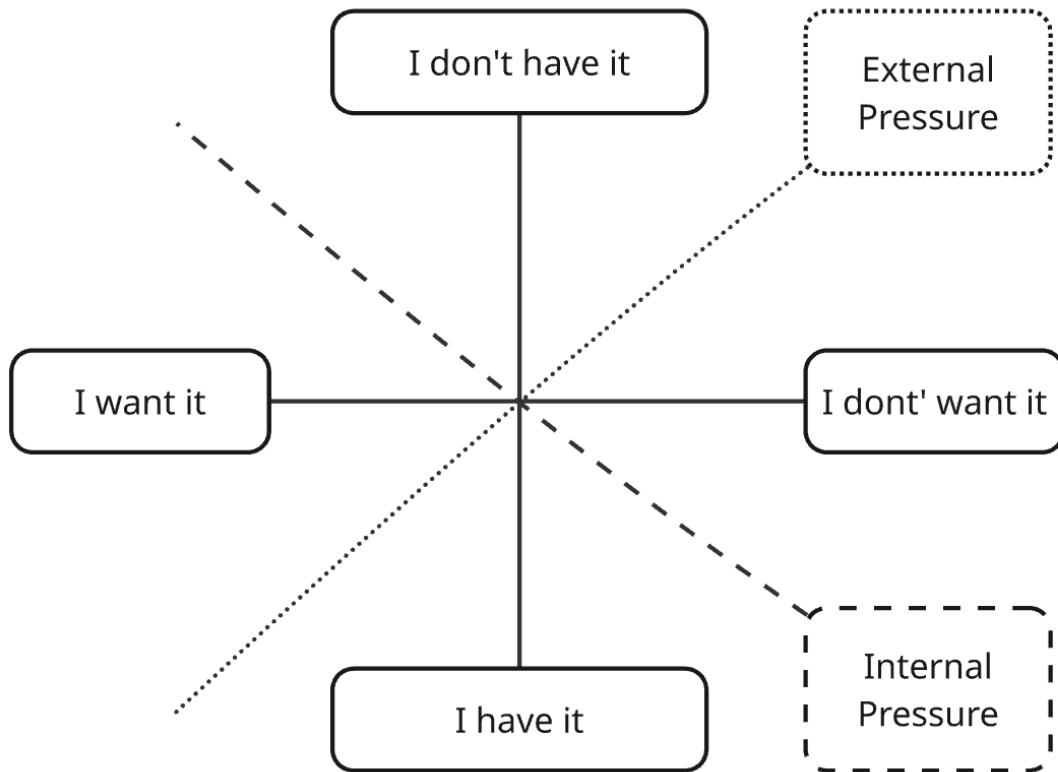
We rely heavily on external goals and usually reserve our intrinsic ones for leisure time, and mostly in the short term. Your "wants" define your behavior in the "now" when you are not pursuing workplace goals or fulfilling obligations for others. Self-gamification is, in a sense, the practice of learning how to define and structure goals for yourself.

Interestingly, we are often better at designing goals for other people. It feels less anxiety-inducing to imagine what others should accomplish. "Should your sister apply for a promotion? What is the best career path for your little brother? What product should your sales team push this week?" Designing goals for yourself feels high stakes. Designing them for others feels simpler.

Game designers take this ability further. They create goals that make you feel good while performing high-effort, often unproductive tasks. Fill a progress bar. Earn a badge. Yes, but not only that. Game designers ask you to save the world, build efficient machines, command armies, or even destroy entire civilizations. Progress bars and badges support the journey, but they are not what make a game compelling. To understand why, we need to return to basics.

A goal is a target you aim for, or a state you try to avoid

Goals in BEM are explained through two axes:



First, the “want axis.” You are either seeking something you desire or trying to avoid something that produces pain or discomfort.

Second, the “state axis.” The thing you desire or want to avoid may be something you already have or something you do not have.

Let’s look at some examples.

- **Don’t have and want:** The most common type of goal. You want to buy a house. You want to gain more clients!
- **Have and don’t want:** Your leg hurts and you cannot walk properly, so you go to the doctor to get yourself checked!
- **Don’t have and don’t want:** Your teammates want you to write a report to present to the board, but you hate writing reports.

- **Have and want:** You are the Head of Product Design, but a new talent threatens your position. You want to keep your current role and avoid being demoted!

As you can see, some goals are driven by **internal pressure**, arising from within. Others are driven by **external factors** that threaten a state you wish to preserve. A designer can create goals that activate internal desires or that create a sense of risk around losing something valuable. But to design better goals, you must understand the power of attraction and anticipation that every goal carries.

When a goal is presented, three things can happen. You may feel driven to act. You may want to act but encounter barriers. Or you may feel apathetic and ignore it altogether.

A goal must generate **attraction**. Attraction captures **attention**. But it must also generate **anticipation**. Take a simple example. Do you want to buy a new house? The idea might capture your attention. It feels desirable. But then you anticipate the years of saving required, the loans, the paperwork, and the uncertainty. That anticipation weakens the drive. The goal loses its pull before it ever translates into action and behaviors!

For a goal to work, it must create both attraction and positive anticipation. Attraction pulls you in. Anticipation makes you believe achievement is within reach. That is why short-term goals are the backbone of game design. Players can foresee success. They can imagine themselves completing the task in the near future. Long-term goals, on the other hand, tend to generate weaker anticipation because the reward feels distant. That is why they must be breadcrumb into smaller, reachable steps that keep the sense of progress alive.

Anticipation is deeply connected to our dopaminergic system

“Make 50 sales phone calls in a day and earn a badge.” Does this feel game-like? Perhaps. Does it create attraction and anticipation? Maybe for collectors or completionists who enjoy accumulating symbols of progress. But for many others, it does not.

Here lies the conundrum of goal design. Tailoring goals to diverse motivational profiles is complex because there are no true universal attractors. Not even money, power, or access function as guaranteed motivators, despite what we once assumed. Really? Consider a few relatable phrases:

- **Money:** “I don’t want that job. It pays double, but it will take time away from my family.”
- **Power:** “I would rather not take that promotion. I could improve the company, but the responsibility and long hours might burn me out.”
- **Access:** “I don’t want a VIP pass to that club. The people in the VIP lounge are insufferable.”

It is not difficult to find reasons to avoid effort. We are very good at rationalizing why something is not worth pursuing. So choosing not to earn a badge by avoiding 50 sales calls a day is not particularly hard, whether the system feels game-like or not.

Of course, a game designer tries to increase the attractiveness of goals. One way to do this is through deferred goals.

Deferred Goals: What People Mistakenly Call Rewards

“I read the bounty description very carefully. It said: ‘For each werewolf banished from this world, I will receive a favor from the Goddess and 15 dracaars.’ Nobody said that the son of Archduke Reginald was out of bounds.”

The tale of Cleric Frenya, in which she received 15 dracaars and a death sentence.

What *if*, for making the 50 phone calls, *then* people receive a coupon for their favorite coffee shop? Loyalty programs were among the first systems to incorporate game-like structures to create incentives. The idea is simple: you “sweeten the deal” by giving something extra for achieving a goal, what most people call a reward.

The classic view is that rewards are external objects: points, badges, trophies, material benefits, stuff. But in BEM, these are goals, not rewards. A reward is not the trophy itself, but the internal reaction to achieving it. The feeling of accomplishment, pride, relief, or validation is the true reward; the external object is just a marker that signals goal completion or update. So while you might call the coffee shop coupon a reward, I call it a *deferred goal*.

What is the difference? Language matters. Calling them rewards primes the designer to believe that what is being offered has universal appeal. “Why wouldn’t anyone want a free coffee?” Well, maybe you do not like coffee. Maybe caffeine makes you anxious. Maybe you avoid it for health reasons. Maybe you dislike the brand. The reasons can vary widely. Which means the so-called “reward” may not be *rewarding* at all!

When you understand deferred goals, you start to see larger incentive structures at play. Take this example from education: “I want to go to university to get a degree. I need the degree to find a job. I need a job to earn money. I need money to live comfortably.” Living comfortably might be the ultimate goal, but each step along the way can function as its own source of meaning and fulfillment, depending on the individual’s motivational profile. Now imagine people begin to believe they can secure well-paying jobs without attending university. The structure shifts. The deferred goal chain changes, and so does the incentive structure.

But beware! If a system imposes a deferred goal without considering the player’s motivations, it can easily backfire. For example: “If you finish the report on time, I will invite you to a fancy dinner.” If the person dislikes fancy dinners, feels uncomfortable in

social situations, or simply does not enjoy the company, the deferred goal becomes a burden rather than a motivator. Instead of increasing attraction.

This illustrates how adding deferred goals increases the complexity of incentive design. This is a way to fall into the trap of extrinsic motivation. Research has repeatedly shown that overreliance on external incentives can reduce intrinsic motivation, weaken performance over time, reduce anticipation and create diminishing returns. Deferred goals can shift attention away from the value of the activity itself and redirect it toward the extra benefit. In our sales example, people might start making low-effort calls just to reach the quota of 50 and secure the coupon, potentially harming customer relationships and long-term results!

If deferred goals, what you previously called rewards, are not always the best solution and must be designed carefully, what alternatives do we have? There is another tool in the gamification toolbox that may be less problematic and more aligned with meaningful design: secondary goals.

Main, Micro and Secondary goals: the real cherry on top of the pie

“The magical map of Varethis lies before me upon the table. The road to the Lich’s castle would mean crossing the paths of the Forgotten Forest. But I could instead venture into the Marshes of the Dead and seek the Holy Chalice of Vaan. With it, I could wield holy water against the lesser skeletal soldiers and perhaps even confront the mighty Wyvern Ghoul. It would be more dangerous, yes, but also far more glorious!”

Of How the Wyvern Ghoul Awoke and Destroyed the Town of Remilis, Vol. I

How many goals can you name in the following screenshot of Mario Bros.?



Let's make a quick analysis, shall we?

1. Hitting the "?" blocks to get coins or power ups.
2. Hitting the bricks to find hidden power up blocks.
3. Picking the mushroom before it leaves the screen.
4. Avoiding being hit by Lakitu's Spinys.
5. Avoiding falling into the pit.
6. Reaching the top block to be able to kill Lakitu.
7. Getting to world 4-2.
8. Reaching the goal in the least time possible.
9. Increasing the score.

Just one snapshot provides multiple targets, which makes games "multi-objective" systems. And most of these objectives operate in short cycles that can be repeated again and again. This creates powerful engagement mechanisms because the brain never goes idle and attention is constantly being re-engaged multiple times per minute of play.

In real life, we cannot usually create cycles that short, but we can approximate them as much as possible!

In real-world contexts, goal cycles depend on the nature of the activity. Still, it will almost always be more engaging to create goals that can be achieved in minutes rather than hours, or in a couple of hours rather than a whole day. The shorter the cycle, the higher the attraction and anticipation of the goal. That is why you should breadcrumb your goals. For example, instead of making "50 phone calls" the only target, each 5 phone calls can be made into a goal in itself.

Micro goals have a higher chance of driving attention and anticipation

Can you implement this kind of system in a workplace or with clients or in the classroom with your students? Yes, with creativity. For instance, following our previous examples, every time someone completes their fifth call, they answer a quick poll online. Can this be cheated? Of course! That is why arbitration mechanisms are necessary. At the end of the day, you should be able to cross-check whether the number of polls answered correlates with the number of calls made.

But micro-goaling is not the only way to drive attraction. Choice is an even stronger driver!

By creating multiple simultaneous goals, you allow different play styles to emerge and attract different types of players. If you are familiar with Richard Bartle's player types, you know that games can support different motivations within the same system. In Mario, some players aim to finish the game as fast as possible. Others want the highest score. Others want to collect everything. Others simply want to survive and pass the levels.

While Mario has only one main objective, to reach the end of each level until you complete the game, secondary objectives are in charge of building the experience and shaping the learning curves.

You can find secondary objectives of the following types:

- **Narrative goals:** the secondary quests that drive players because of their narrative outcome. Saving someone, helping an NPC, changing the world, these are examples of the narrative layer.
- **Declared goals with incentives:** these are voluntary goals that include deferred goals to create attraction. They are not required, but they are used to move different player profiles toward additional content. For example, if you complete a side quest, you earn the Sword of Engagement!
- **Affordance goals:** goals that are created by placing keys, levers or other systems that players know have some kind of specific effect. Found a key? Let's find a lock. Is there a lever? Let's see what it moves.
- **Arbitrary nudged goals:** these are goals that are pressured by the interface itself. Having a trophy room might push you towards trying to get all the badges. While the game doesn't state that you'll win something for achieving them, they do provide a clear signal that the goal is achievable. They are highly dependent on intrinsic drive and should be optional.
- **Emergent goals:** goals that are created by the players themselves, inspired by the possibilities that the game system creates. Usually they are goals that were not actively nudged by the designers. Some games don't have time counters, but still Speedrunners might find a way to make the game about finishing it as fast as possible.

While this might seem daunting, we will be giving multiple examples in this Book. For the time being, the important part is to understand that:

The BEM disciple loves multi-objective systems and short cycles to drive anticipation.

But all of these goals work if they are framed under the scope of a **main goal**. Goals give direction and help modulate attention, but if you have too many things to do, you just might lose your way! That is why every game creates a series of main declared goals that help nudge players towards progress and reduce the scope of action.

In Mario the main goals are three: defeat each level, avoid losing lives and get to the final boss and beat it! Many games have this basic structure, designing some rails that make sure the player keeps going in a main direction. They can explore the system all they want, but they still have to find a way forward.

Main goals have some characteristics that are great to keep in consideration:

1. They become more challenging over time, but usually start easy to allow for early victories.
2. They allow the game to move forward. Not completing a main goal does not punish you, but if you don't complete it you won't be able to continue your progress. They become gateways of skill.
3. Each game has a small number of main goal types that are reused. Variety is tackled using secondary goals.
4. Main goals create overarching structures for your design.
5. They can have performance metrics to incentivize replay, like the classic three star system of mobile games.

Let's create an example for driving motivation on a high school teacher:

Main goal		
Design a gamified classroom using 5 micro secondary goals per class and a narrative background.		
Secondary Declared goal	Affordance goal	Arbitrary goal
High performance badge: The teacher may incorporate mechanics where students can try to achieve high performance goals for extra badges. These should be optional.	Feedback cards: As the teacher progresses in design iterations, they “find” random cards that provide tips to use certain feedback elements. There is no explicit goal on how to use them, but they invite ideas of design.	Design combo: Teachers have a streak counter for delivering design iterations on time. There is no consequence for losing or increasing the streak counter.

This structure seeks to ensure some teachers will make an extra effort by engaging with one or the three optional systems, while ensuring they will not lose the main focus of incorporating the 5 micro secondary goals into their classes.

This structure seeks to ensure some teachers will do an extra effort by engaging with one or the three optional systems, but ensuring they will not lose the main focus of incorporating the 5 micro secondary goals into their classes.

Action vs State Goals: behaviors and strategies

One last important element of the BEM toolkit is understanding how to create goals that are not “farmable” or “cheatable”. Classic gamification used to have a strong emphasis on behavioral goals, for example, “doing phone calls”. These systems failed for multiple reasons, but one of those is precisely that trying to pressure behaviors creates unintended effects, like cheating the system, or reducing the performance while doing the behavior.

This happens because it creates “farming” mechanics, which are easy repeatable goals that yield benefits each time they are completed. The most basic farmable mechanic would be: “press a button and gain 1 coin”. Farmable systems allow the creation of cheap reusable content in game design, like the “kill 50 boars” in World of Warcraft, but they always feel like work and players will find ways of automatizing the result, like creating bots that farm the benefits.

While action-based goals are dangerous when you have deferred goals and clear completion benefits, they might be better driven using feedback based design, but will talk about feedback later on, so let's put a pin on this. By the time being, let's think of another kind of strategy: stateful goals.

These are goals that are measured by achieving states that are not totally in control of the players. Sports are a great reference, as you have actual opposition to get to your goals, and you have to increase your skills to be able to achieve them. Scoring in basketball is not about the behavior of throwing the ball, it is about making the ball pass through the loop, which makes throwing the ball the best behavior. But you can have different scoring models, like the 3-pointers, which makes the players think strategically and analyse information to make informed choices. Let's write the rule to make this clearer:

"If the player throws the ball outside the 3-point line and the ball passes through the loop, then the team gets 3 points".

As you can see, the player has a level of agency, as they can choose from where to throw, but the goal depends on a state (the ball passing through the loop) and not on a behavior per se. Basically, you don't score points for throwing, which would make it an action goal, and would make the game objectively worse.

BEM disciples prefer to search for stateful goals that can drive creativity.

While many projects can revolve around making people "do stuff", we have to think how "doing that stuff" might be the best strategy to achieve higher level goals. Action-based goals are part of the design process, but not the final goal of the design: in Mario you can farm for coins, but engagement comes from the skillful segments of the game where effort is required.

Now, let's keep in mind that stateful goals can become almost action-based goals when the player becomes skillful enough. While killing a boar should require effort and strategy and will be fun for a player, a "kill 50 boars" quest usually appears when killing a boar becomes low effort, and you start feeling that you are only smashing buttons.

So let's turn the "make 50 sales phone calls around". The better game-able goal could be to get 10 leads on a day that ask for more information via email. Now the player does not have full control on the result and has to develop strategies. Create a strategy guide and some tracking systems and you start having a game.

But be careful! Stateful goals should be designed with the odds of achievement in mind, this is, the difficulty of the task. What if the player never gets the 10 leads? What if a salesperson, regardless of effort, manages to get 4 to 6 daily, because the market is just not as interested, or has hit a skill roof? Maybe we should use *relative goalposts*.

Relative goalposts: making competition fun

Sports are high-skill, high-performance activities, and people train consistently to become as good as possible in the game. This makes stateful goals feel achievable, but in these scenarios you need opponents or difficulty curves that are aligned with those skills. You don't want a novice tennis player playing against Federer. That's why Chess has the ELO system and many games have a way to *rank and match* their players.

But, while getting 10 leads is something you either achieve or not, in sports or board games the goal is usually to get *more* points *than* your opponent. Let's use our goal formula to make it clearer: *if* you get *more* points *than* your opponents, *then* you are declared victorious. The goal post is not an absolute number, it is a relative one, which creates a system where the results are uncertain until the end.

It doesn't have to be face-to-face zero sum games! Let's try something different: *If* you get as many leads as the top 60% of salespeople in the company, *then* you enter a new league. You have ensured that the roof is achievable within the system, because someone within the system has set that record! Now the goalpost is relative to other people's performance and not an arbitrary number. This is one of the tricks that most modern board games use: you have a scoring track, but you don't have to get a particular score, just be sure to score more than the other players, or the *automa* (a board game AI opponent) in cooperative or solo games.

Now, there are important design principles when you use relative goalposts, for example, the closer the scores, the more engaging the game! If someone got 150 points and you got 20, maybe you won't play that game again. But if you got 146, the story shifts. You will have to design scoring engines that ensure these results. Let me give you a more complete rulebook for our salesperson:

- Each phone call you make scores 1 point.
- Each lead before the 5th scores 4 points.
- Each lead after the 5th scores 2 points.

Wait, we are creating a farmable goal! Yes, but this goal is there just for the sake of giving what game designers call **gimmick points**. Basically, the idea is that you know that each average salesperson will do 50 to 60 calls a day, which ensures 100 to 120 effortless points. But then you have your **marginal points**: each lead has a higher impact towards victory, but you get less as you move forward to avoid creating a bigger gap. Why give the gimmick points? Why reduce the points overtime? Let's compare the three scenarios with two hypothetical players.

Player A	Player B
----------	----------

7 leads: (7×4) : 28 pts.	15 leads: (15×4) : 60 pts.
7 leads: $(5 \times 4) + (2 \times 2) = 24$ pts.	15 leads: $(5 \times 4) + (10 \times 2) = 40$ pts.
100 calls: 100 pts. 7 leads: $(5 \times 3) + (2 \times 2) = 24$ pts. Total: 124 pts	105 calls: 105 pts. 9 leads: $(5 \times 3) + (10 \times 2) = 40$ pts. Total: 145 pts

Just reducing the gap by reducing the points after the 5th lead makes the scores feel *relatively* more close. But by creating the gimmick points, while the absolute gap is bigger by five, the competition feels even closer. In the second case player A got almost half the score of player B, but in the third case it's only 86%!

By adjusting the goalposts in this relative manner, the goal's difficulty is relative to what the system accepts and not arbitrary targets, but by designing the engines you have control on the types of outcomes you can have, making the "game" more satisfying to your users.

The BEM disciple understands that designing goals is not just creating the goalpost, but having the ability to ensure the outcome is satisfying!

Cycle and Chained goals for building loops

One of the main problems with "badging" is that getting a badge as a goal is a closed system with a clear end: once you get the badge, there is nothing more to do! When goals don't have a follow up, don't trigger another goal or create the conditions for players to want to try to complete again the same mission, players will stop playing.

Think of the difference between these goals:

Closed goal	Cycle goal	Chained goal
Do exercise until you lose X weight. You'll get a badge!	Do 20 push ups daily. Get a new badge every 30 days.	If you lose X weight, then you have to do 20 push ups daily.

The closed goal can have many effects, some obvious, some more complex. In this case, the person might just stop doing exercise when they get to their target weight, but in worst scenarios, the person might start eating more to compensate for the tension that completing the goal provided. This has been seen in real life where people after losing weight with strict diets bounce back and recover the weight quicker than expected.

Cycle goals are about creating habits, or at least nudging people into increased persistence. While doing the first day doesn't ensure you do it again the second time, at least the chances increase, as the goal is not closed. Behavioral approaches rely a lot on this type of goal.

The last one chains one goal with the next. This is one of the preferred methods used in game design and can help combine the other two modalities. Getting new goals can become a goal in itself which is very powerful to drive excitement! Also, this helps to manage your system complexity, as you don't have to tell your player everything they have to accomplish from the get go. With this kind of goal the game **unfolds** and feels more alive.

Feedback: Interaction and emotion

If goals define what players strive for and create attraction and anticipation, feedback defines how they perceive progress and self-correct. Feedback is the mechanism that transforms goal pursuit into a neurological trigger. Without effective feedback, goals lose meaning, and engagement fails to materialize. Let's give a definition so we can start building from there:

Feedback is an output signal that becomes an input within the system, altering the system behavior.

If you work in education, you might think that designing feedback is about *pushing information* to your students, but actually it's more of a 2-way conversation, it's about *interaction*. Interactive systems have subparts that communicate among themselves to help the system "evolve" in a certain way. Think of a car that starts beeping because it's too close to a wall: it has sent a signal for the driver to correct a behavior. Now the driver communicates back by hitting the brake, and then moving away from the wall, which sends the signal to the car to re-assess. The car finally stops beeping, ending the conversation. The car influenced the driver, and the driver influenced the car to avoid a collision, to achieve a goal, and without feedback the goal might have been failed.

In education, you send information to your students and then they send information as a response back, and the way these signals are designed might end up motivating the teacher and students, or demotivating them both. Everyone is affected! Maybe you made a harsh comment on an essay, which made the student decide not to deliver the next homework, which makes you use more punitive measures. Every aspect of the system is determined by all these signals that happen as a response to others. That is the power of feedback!

The idea that feedback creates these cycles of interaction is why we call these *feedback loops*, and the way they affect the system is heavily studied in systemic analysis. We will cover feedback loops with more care later on, but suffice to say for now that great game

and system designers are experts on feedback loop design, and BEM disciples should be no different. And keep in mind that, the same as with goals, feedback systems are built over conditionals.

Games provide some of the clearest examples of feedback loops. In *Guitar Hero*, the moment a player hits a note, they receive immediate visual and auditory confirmations. *If* the player makes a successful hit, *then* the game produces a satisfying sound and maintains their combo streak. A missed note, in contrast, *results* in a dull click and interrupts the music, signaling failure. This immediate and layered feedback ensures that players remain deeply engaged with the task, continually refining their skills in pursuit of mastery, which means the system can evolve towards more challenging songs and higher skills, in a loop.

Outside of games, consider how feedback works in social media. *If* a user posts a picture, *then* they receive likes and comments. Each interaction acts as feedback, reinforcing engagement. However, poorly designed feedback loops can have unintended consequences—like social media addiction—where users become fixated on external validation rather than the intrinsic value of sharing experiences. A misplaced “thumbs down” button can drive motivation to the floor and most social media platforms avoid them.

Feedback is so important, that it might change the whole way we perceive a goal! Imagine what would happen if you got your 5th lead in our previous “phone calls” game but nothing alerts you to this accomplishment. On the other hand, imagine that you didn’t know that there was an incentive to get the 5th lead but the moment you get it for the first time you receive a push notification with a simple “Congratulations! You have crossed the 5th lead threshold!”. While goals might drive attraction and anticipation, the feedback systems create the context for anticipation, or the pay-off for that anticipation, and are in charge of driving engagement and *Experience*!

A well-designed system ensures that feedback isn’t just a reaction to an action but a guiding force that shapes the user’s *behavior and cognition*, reinforcing meaningful engagement rather than shallow gratification. But to actually design interesting feedback, we need a minimum basis of understanding of what we are seeking as BEM disciples.

The discriminatory coherent signal

Feedback can be unclear, it can be contradictory and confusing. Humans tend to use spontaneous feedback that might be altered by mood states or by their relationship with the receiver of the feedback. The rules might vary from person to person, which might make what the feedback means hard to understand. And a single feedback element might be trying to pack more information that the receiver can unpack!

Feedback has a *cognitive value*, which depends on how we interpret the signal. And the cognitive value is key for learning and behavior change. So people that work on education should be the best at giving feedback, right? Wrong! Our whole educational system is based on the type of confusing feedback I presented above. Let's break it down:

- Teachers can react differently to the same questions depending on their mood or who asks the question. While they can be assertive with a student they like, they usually tend to be more critical with students that are more rebellious.
- In a numeric scale for grading in a University, every teacher might interpret the goalposts differently. In Colombia people are graded over 5, and I remember that my teachers in literature would seldom grade someone below 4.0, with an exemption of a couple of teachers. At the same time, people that studied music tended to have trouble getting a 3.5. As scholarships were given for the highest grades in a semester, literature students were almost always the beneficiaries of these "differed goals".
- A 4.5 might try to convey information on grammar, the quality of ideas, the analytic components, the use of quotations and more, but it is impossible to know how to discriminate between each component of the evaluation system, unless the teacher gives a lot of justification in written form. My 4.5 could be a product of a different equation from another student's.

In game design, feedback needs to be discriminatory, which means that each important trigger has its own signal. The iconic sound of grabbing a coin in Mario Bros is so ingrained in our culture that you are hearing it right now, and that's because that sound doesn't appear almost anywhere else. Opening a can of soda or beer has a distinct sound that cannot be easily confused, and there have been designers of plastic bottles that have been trying to create similar artificially designed sounds for their products. This is so important that many EV car companies incorporate artificial "engine" sound to their cars because users felt like the vehicle wasn't working.

We learn what a discriminatory signal means, which facilitates cognition.

But for a signal to work well over time it can't mutate, it must be coherent and reliable. If the sound of car engines changed every year, we would get confused when we hear a car approaching on the street.

It has been shown that people tend to increase their skills of prediction in a system, when that system provides clear, predictable, feedback rules. In systems where we get conflicting information and feedback, like political experts or hard to diagnose medical scenarios, it becomes harder to actually make predictions and act accordingly. Do you have a headache? Good luck finding the cause, as it is not a discriminatory signal, and it can mutate over time.

Our body has one of the worst feedback system designs, which make medicine one of the hardest disciplines to learn. In confusing systems of information you rely more on your biases and experiences to simplify your world view, which makes learning and change harder. This explains things like the mistrust on medical advice and our propensity to seek second opinions.

A gamification designer needs to think of feedback as *conditional rulesets*. If the learner makes more than 5 grammatical mistakes, *then* it gets a red flag in the upper red corner of the paper. If the red flag means this, and only this, the learner will be able to unpack reliably that information and act accordingly, facilitating cognition. Gamification has been used successfully in medicine to help improve medical students' skills, as it helps provide a clearer feedback framework to learn from, even if the underlying diagnosis still depends on this messy biological feedback system.

The BEM disciple makes the best effort to create univocal, immutable feedback systems that convey only small packets of information.

Feedback Information for emotional contagion

One of the main pillars of BEM is understanding that feedback is not useful only for its cognitive value. Humans have a tendency rooted in tradition to focus on feedback as a way to “give information”, usually about performance, as we like to criticize and correct by nature. If you think of a gamified course, you might be thinking that we are talking about telling the player why they missed the mark. While the cognitive aspect of feedback is important, it is by far not the most important part that our brains judge.

Think about how many conversations don’t revolve on what is being said, but around how it is being said. This is because each signal has an inherent and cultural emotional value. Why do we use green to mean “go on” and red to mean “beware!”. This is not universal, but we tend to learn emotional codes on colors, sounds, animations and so on.

One of my main critiques on most gamified systems I have come across is that they incorporate the “game elements”, like badges and points, but they are too lazy to incorporate their emotional value. While in a gamified Learning Management System you might get some points and advance a progress bar, it seldom has the same impact like the way an actual game does! A game doesn’t want you to just “know” that you won something, it wants to help you feel good about it.

Think on the difference between these feedback systems:

Just cognitive approach	Emotional approach
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+2 points New badge: "Explorer"	An animation of a +2 appears on the screen scaling in and bouncing back a couple of times, as a sound shows how your points counter is moving up. Next, a badge appears rotating fast on the screen and accelerating until a victorious fanfare sounds and the badge illuminates on the screen.
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While the cognitive information is the same, the emotional information is completely different. The second version wants to trigger the reward system of the brain at all costs and tries to tell the user how they should feel about it.

In our everyday life this is so clear that memes and emojis are mostly designed to convey a lot of emotional information, and just a little bit of cognitive data. Virality usually revolves around emotion, not about content, which makes us vulnerable to being manipulated by conflicting information. The confirmation bias works around selecting the information that makes us feel good.

The BEM disciple thinks about the delivery and the emotional component of the feedback systems, not just the cognitive information.

Be careful! Emotional design might mean to you "how to make players happy!", but sometimes to create big emotions like Fiero (the feeling of great accomplishment after completing a daunting task) you need to first create a bit of frustration. Making the player hate a character is important to make the victory against it even more compelling. You need to play with the whole range of emotions.

Feedback as attention re-capturers

Hey, look here! This is important! Feedback also affects attention!

Video games use all the interactive signals in their disposal to keep your eyes on the screen, more than any other form of design. Well, almost all: real-time trackers like the ones used in the stock exchange can drive the same kind of obsessive attention, and that is why experts usually recommend people to avoid looking at their stocks at all times.

This happens because feedback are conditional signals based on interaction, which makes them *dynamic*, and dynamism is better to maintain attention than static systems. Want to make your powerpoint presentation more engaging? Easy, make 100 slides instead of 20, and change slides every 5 seconds: that's almost the rate of change of a comic book or a

movie. In movies camera angles and shots change almost every second just to keep you looking at the screen and long scenes with little camera movement are harder to focus on.

When things are static, you need to use your executive attention system, which is the one where you voluntarily direct your attention. This system is rewarded by a process called attention seeking, which is finding the moment when you receive data that makes that effort worth it. But when things are dynamic, you are capturing the automatic attention system, which is reacting to changing visual and sound queues. You heard a loud Boom! You look that way as a reflex!

While I think the overuse of attention re-capturers as the ones used in action video games create attentional deficit problems, as we lose the ability to focus using our executive attention, the proper use of these systems can help you tell the brain of your users when something is really important.

So, ask the question? When my user archives a milestone or a goal, how can I make sure they know about it? Make sure to use animation, movement and sounds to increase the value of your feedback systems, to attract the brain by using clear signals.

The BEM disciple uses feedback as a way to allow the brain to know where to look and when.

Multi-signal feedback: reinforcement and divergence

If you analyze how game feedback systems work you will find something uncommon in real life: a single trigger or goal isn't associated with just one feedback signal. Take this case for instance: you defeat an enemy in Final Fantasy XIII and you get a report screen with the time it took you to defeat the enemy, your overall combat performance in a 5-star rating, a gain in XP points, and the skills you unlocked. Why not make it simple and create one feedback signal for each feedback rule? There are two main reasons games do it like that: **reinforcing** and **diverging**.

Reinforcing means that you send different signals to show you the same thing in different ways. In Guitar Hero, when you strike a perfect note you can get a "fire animation" over the key, an increase in a score multiplier, a lighting bulb lights up related to that score multiplier, the crowd in the background gets excited, you see and hear lighting bolts and the animation of the character holding the guitar makes an exciting move. All of this information is talking about your performance, but redundancy creates experience and ensures you actually **get the message**.

On the other hand, **divergence** is about finding a way to keep you engaged with the right information, and is related to multi-objective systems. If a single rule moves a performance indicator, but also shows you how you're increasing your power, you might

feel more excitement with one of the two signals. This way, I can try to move different motivational profiles at the same time.

These signals can be chaotic but games have another tool up their sleeve to make things work, even in complex, heavy feedback-based games like Balatro: the **signal queue**. The idea is you don't provide all the information in one go, but by steps. Final Fantasy XIII first shows you your battle time, then it shows you your score, then it shows you the stars you won, then the characters' XP progress bars get filled. Multi-signal feedback does not mean "simultaneous" feedback, as this increases confusion. This is specially important in digital gamification projects, where you need to code your feedback rules!

The BEM disciple doesn't rely on simple feedback mechanisms all the time, but takes advantage of more gameful multi-signal approaches for reinforcing a message, or giving emotional choice.

Feedback and the algorithms of evaluation

This topic will be better discussed in the Chapter on Mastery of this book, but it is important to understand that feedback rules are algorithms that incorporate rules, which means the feedback system will always be a means of evaluation.

Look at the next example from the realm of gamified education:

"If the student attempts to write a sentence in formal Japanese, then:

1. If the Kanjis are correct, the Kanji for *power* is stamped in the paper in a congratulatory font. If not, a counter of errors appears instead.
2. For each error in a Hiragana character, a sad Pokemon appears near the mistake.
3. If the grammar is correct, an anime character is drawn on the page with a "Yatta" (Great!) sign on the side. If not, the character appears with a confused face and the Kanji for "Nani" (what?) appears next to its face.

This might seem to be a lot of trouble to design, but this is what game designers do to help our players be able to self-diagnose! Evaluation algorithms in our feedback rules are the reason why players can become so skillful in our games! Let's discuss these better later.

Immediate or delayed? Not a simple answer

Research suggests that feedback loses its power if it's delayed, but my experience designing games and gamification systems disagree with this universal claim. Delaying feedback can be a great way to build anticipation and create engagement loops.

For example, if I tell you the results of a poll will be given to you the next morning, now you have a reason to come back and will build expectations for the result. Have you played a game where you try to collect something but a timer appears telling you to wait a couple of hours? That's because game designers know the power of delayed feedback! Well, you still get some immediate feedback telling you to wait, but the main signal is delayed nonetheless.

Because of this, BEM uses the following design principles:

- **Immediate feedback:** required when users need immediate information to take action or to understand their current state. It's great to help the user avoid accumulating mistakes over time and help them to make quick corrective behaviors.
- **Delayed feedback:** used to create anticipation and emotion over an important consequence. Maybe making you wait 5 seconds before telling you you won a golden ticket is better, right? Here you don't have to take immediate action and building anticipation is better for the experience.
- **Scheduled feedback:** this creates delay in bigger cycles, but it tells the user when they will receive the information. One of our best gamification projects, which was awarded two Gamicon awards, including *Best Overall Use of Gamification*, had to give the results of player actions with a two day delay. Why? The client could not get the data sooner. But we built a schedule and players did not mind, because every day at 8am they would get a push notification reporting that they could claim their "rewards" for what they did two days prior.
- **Untimely feedback:** this is the one we want to avoid. When the feedback comes at a time when it's no longer useful, or when the user has forgotten the context required to make sense of that feedback, then we are doing it wrong! I struggle with this when I teach gamification classes, because I know I should give feedback to my student designs as soon as possible, but I seldom can because of everything else I'm doing in my life. I try to make every effort to avoid this because I understand these principles.
- **Devalued feedback:** this is the feedback that loses its value merely because it comes so late that the power of anticipation is diminished. Maybe the signal is still useful, but it doesn't drive excitement any more.

The key takeaway is to avoid believing that immediate feedback is the only way to go, but understand that:

Feedback devalues overtime so the BEM disciple needs to make sure that feedback cycles are short enough depending on the use case.

Feedback to manage failure

This will be a big topic later on, but the picture of feedback would not be complete if we don't talk on how feedback design is more important when the users are failing on their tasks, than when we are succeeding. I have found, through my designs and working teaching about gamification, that most people have a bias towards designing congratulatory feedback. And even worse, when they are asked to manage the feedback for failure states they tend to punish with harsh feedback. But this practice, in systems that are so reliant on failure for learning, like games, is dangerous, as you are pushing your player away when they need you to hold them up!

Games find ways to make mistakes bearable through several mechanisms, like reducing the losses, creating quick recovery scenarios, but also by making feedback *uncertainty reduction mechanisms*. What this means is that each time you get feedback, you know more about how to tackle a problem, without revealing the solution. The feeling that the next time I will do it better is the key to incentivize retrying and avoid crossing the frustration threshold. Let's state the principle for now and we will discuss the mechanisms later:

The BEM disciple worries more about the failure states, as they are critical for avoiding player loss.

The notification: unexpected feedback systems

Notifications are information that is being pushed by the system, not as an answer to a user interaction, but as a state rule. Notifications work using the same rules of feedback systems, we just need to understand that in these cases the user is not initiating the conversation, but an algorithm. Again, notifications are conditional clauses, and you can see interesting applications for example in a rule used by Duolingo:

"If a user doesn't login in a couple of days, then the system pushes a message showing Duo missing the player. This rule is repeated a couple of times more, but if it doesn't work, the system pushes a message telling the user that Duo will not bother them anymore".

In this example, the *if... then...* clauses are trying to build emotion through discriminatory signals that are intended to drive behavior correction. The user can engage in the conversation by reengaging with the App, or ignore it.

Notifications can be invasive if you get information you don't want that takes your attention from more important stuff, and game designers make sure to build notification systems that are not just about the business goals. When in a video game you hear an

alert telling you you are being attacked from behind, that notification is so valuable to the player that, if you don't send the push, you might enrage your user. If you understand what you need to notify, know the proper channel and time to do so, and avoid nagging the user, you can have a very powerful notifications system.

The BEM disciple understands the power and pitfall of notifications systems, as conversations started by the game and not the user.

Rewards: not something you can give

When we talked about goals we stated that what people call rewards, in BEM are actually deferred goals. "Buy 10 items and win a Hamburger!" In this statement the Hamburger is a goal that you decide to pursue or not. It has attraction and anticipation value, and that's the main reason these kinds of systems are put in place in retail and commerce. But now imagine that you make the effort, win the Hamburger and then you take a bite... yuck! All the anticipation becomes deception and punishment when you notice it has low grade meat and an awful sauce! You engaged with the goal, but the feedback you receive (the taste) actually triggers displeasure!

A critical flaw in many designs is the assumption that rewards are something the designer *can give*. In reality, rewards exist only in the player's mind as a neurological response to achieving a goal *and* receiving feedback. What designers can do is structure goals and feedback mechanisms that increase the likelihood of triggering this response.

Our brains have a reward system mainly, but not exclusively, located in the dorsal striatum, which is regulated by many hormones and neurotransmitters, like dopamine, oxytocin, serotonin, neurotensins, and more. This system might be triggered by external and internal factors, like imagining a great idea, or taking a bite on a hamburger. And it's a complex system related to our stress response, our ability to create memories, and triggers for behavior change. In this sense,

*You can give the Hamburger to try to trigger a reward, but you can't **give** a reward*

The PBL elephant in the room

Reward and punishment are two sides of the same coin, and you can't have one without the other. Designing the promise of getting a badge, means also designing the possibility of frustration from someone incapable of getting that badge. Gaining points can be rewarding, but if you advance too slowly towards your goal, it can become exasperating.

Designing a leaderboard where the top players will be rewarded, means punishing to different degrees all other players.

And humans are resilient to frustration and punishment, but only to a point. When we talk of goals as systems of anticipation, that anticipation is mediated by your expectation of triggering this reward or punishment response, which is reinforced by experience. Maybe you've taken many courses with badges and points, but the courses themselves were low quality in content and experience: now you expect every course with points and badges to be low quality, you anticipate the punishment.

Points, badges and other game elements can anticipate punishment if not designed correctly.

When this happens, I might later on design a badge collection for a course expecting to create a goal that anticipates reward, but my user can actually interpret it as: "another course with badges? I should avoid it at all costs!" Now the goal of the user becomes one of avoidance and my gamification initiative fails from the very outset.

Of course, it might be the case that a user has been in great and awful gamified courses, which means they can't expect punishment, but they can't expect excitement as well. This is closer to reality in many cases, as results in the real world tend to be mixed. It even happens in games! Of course, there are great games out there, but also some really terrible ones, which means that selecting a game in a marketplace is a process full of tension and anxiety for those of us who play a lot. To avoid this we find mechanisms to pick the good apples, like watching reviews or hearing recommendations. But in most gamification projects you can't do that. These mixed signals lower the overall anticipation and after 13 years of working on the field I have seen all the range.

And the problem is nowhere clearer than when you talk about PBLs. Points, badges and leaderboards were regarded as rewards themselves, which were said to be the key to engagement because "modern" games were using them everywhere. The initial appeal was there: they were easy to implement, you could give them to anyone at no cost, and "anyone" could design them. The industry then started dumping these systems everywhere with little consideration to how they actually work in the game industry and the many considerations around their use. These led to many failed projects, which created a very vocal backlash against them: if it had PBLs it was doomed to fail!

PBLs should be a warning to anyone that thinks that rewarding people is an easy, industrializable task. Games are complex systems where if any part fails, it can take the whole game down with it. An unbalance and unfairness in a system can create havoc on its users and a "fun" experience might become the object of rage. PBLs have been great in certain designs that have used them with care, and points, badges and leaderboards will not disappear from the human experience. Points are so ingrained in our culture that it's almost impossible to think of anything game-like without them! But a game is not good *because* it has points.

From anticipation to reality

Let's begin with another example of what someone might consider a *reward*.

"If you read 50 blog posts on gamification, you win a free gamification consultancy!"

This might seem like an attractive "*reward*", especially if you are reading this book, but... what is truly happening? The system is setting up a deferred goal where anticipation builds over time. As you start reading blog posts you get closer to getting the consultancy, and this might drive you to keep going! But what if the person does not perceive any value in the consultancy? Then the incentive collapses, as there is no **anticipation** of reward, so the build up is lost. The user becomes *apathetic* and no additional drive happens.

But it might be worse! Maybe someone was eager to read my blog posts just for fun or education, but I have shifted the **focus of anticipation** towards the consultancy. Someone might now *avoid* reading my blog posts, because, if I'm eager to offer something in exchange, I should offer something of better value. It becomes a negotiation. The free consultancy might actually make some people be driven away from my blog posts!

This reminds me of an experiment by Dan Ariely where he offered one of his classes to pay them so they would go see him recite poetry, but to another class he asked them to pay him to attend. The first group would not perceive the intrinsic value of the event and would charge money as if it was a favor to Ariely, while the second was inclined to pay for the privilege. This framing effect is important, because the *deferred goal might actually change your perception of the main one*. Maybe if I charge you to read those 50 blog posts you will actually be more driven to read them! In this sense, designing the goal and the feedback system becomes an experiment, one the BEM designer is better equipped to tackle because it's not biased by the preconception of things being "intrinsically rewarding".

Now, let's say you read one of those blog posts and you receive a notice that says: "You have started the hard but amazing journey towards becoming a gamification hero! You have read 1 of 50 beginner posts". Feedback has a more direct impact on the reward system, which makes it more important to drive motivation in the future! Of course, not any feedback has the same value. You might ask yourself, was telling the reader it has to read 50 more posts a good idea? Maybe not! Goals require feedback, but feedback informs goals! This means that breadcrumbing is important to keep the reader engaged.

The BEM disciple understands that the relationship between goal and feedback is what trigger reward responses

To really design powerful systems you need to always keep in mind that things are never intuitive in the field of motivations, or we would have solved it a long time ago. This is always an experimental matter, but one that can be informed better by the right design

framework, one that doesn't assume rewards are out there to give, but that assumes the human experience is complex, and what we do is help nudge that complexity by crafting better goals and better feedback systems.

A new old language for rewards

But, how can we speak about rewards? Here we can fallback to the theories of the needs, like Self-Determination theory. Understanding the need is a better way to try to build the experiment, as then the goal and feedback should be aligned to satisfy that need. Another quick example: If a workplace provides a bonus for reaching sales targets, the true motivator isn't the money itself, but the emotional and psychological impact it carries—security, recognition, validation. The same applies to games: in *Dark Souls*, defeating a boss doesn't shower the player with excessive loot or cutscenes. Instead, the hard-earned victory triggers an internal response—relief, pride, and a sense of personal growth. The loot and cutscenes are part of the equation as well, of course, but we should focus on the driver, not the target!

BEM has a model to talk about those rewards in a meaningful way, a model of 7 drivers that helps us focus on what's important, but first let's get something important out of the way.

Intrinsic or Extrinsic? It's not about the rewards

I want to explain now how we in BEM understand the concepts of intrinsic and extrinsic motivation, and how we design around the problems that arise from motivational theories. It is impossible to talk about motivation without understanding this problem, because it can actually help us guide the way we design goals and feedback systems.

Usually people talk about extrinsic and intrinsic rewards, but, as we have stated, in BEM rewards are the neurological triggers that happen as a result of receiving goal-oriented feedback, which means, rewards *are always intrinsic*. So how can we define if something is extrinsic? Well, we need to go back to goals and feedback design.

Imagine I give you this goal: "You should design a gamification framework for high school teachers, using the BEM framework". The source of the goal is *external*, you did not decide to build that framework, the goal was pushed from the outside, from me. Does this make the whole activity extrinsic? No, because you then decide to add your own goals to the activity: "I want to incorporate elements of Design Thinking and define the framework using the works of Piaget". These goals were self-determined, which makes them *intrinsic*.

Extrinsic and intrinsic goals cohabitate in any activity, which modulates the way a person behaves. You will be more aroused and activated by the things that move you than by the things you are asked for. Maybe the framework ends up having more Design Thinking and more Piaget than BEM. But maybe it so happens that my external request aligns with your internal drives! To explain this case we need to expand our vision and add another layer.

Introjection, Integration and Regulation

I found the Organismic Integrated Theory (a branch of Self-Determination Theory) to be revealing on this aspect. Edward Deci and Richard Ryan create an “extrinsicity” grayscale, where some things are more extrinsic, while others are more aligned with those inner drives. The problem is their theory is too convoluted to be used as a framework of design, so I decided to simplify it, again using game design as a framework of analysis. Let me explain my results.

Games are often referred to as voluntary activities. One of the definitions of games a like the most comes from Bernard Suits, who said that:

*“Playing a **game** is a **voluntary** attempt to overcome **unnecessary obstacles**”*

If playing games is voluntary, that seems to point to games as intrinsic activities: to play a game is an intrinsic goal in itself. But, wait! Games are full of extrinsic elements, like badges, swords and other stuff that is *extrinsically* promised to the players for completing activities and achieving those goals! This inner paradox baffled me for a long time, as games have been inspiring the use of extrinsic motivation for a long time!

Think about it... loyalty programs, contests, raffles, sweepstakes, everything game-like in marketing has been about extrinsic goals: play and win! But we know that games generate intrinsic drive, as that has been the point of *Meaningful Gamification*. The works of Jane McGonigall, Sebastian Detering, Scott Nicholson and myself have been focusing on how games move people internally, which comes with added productivity and quality of work!

Finally, by reading the OIT I found a way to reconcile this: the desire to play games is intrinsic, but the mechanisms games use themselves are not, they come in a variety of *extrinsic flavors*, some which are more harmful, others which are better *aligned* with the players’ goals. How does this alignment work and why is it important?

Most non-mobile, non-manipulative, non-monetization-centered games try to align goals and feedback with internal needs, but their internal not just relative to user’s goals, but also within the system itself. The consequences of doing an action is valuable to keep performing that action: buy a new sword, improve your armor, raise your skill points, all these extrinsic elements are aligned with the activity of battling monsters and baddies! While making the battle fun is about designing around intrinsic drive, all the other extrinsic elements revolve around that fun activity, enhancing it in a way.

When an extrinsic goal and its feedback system is aligned with the inner drive of the activity you are doing, that goal is not totally external, it is **introjected**. This means that the external consequences are aligned as much as possible with the intrinsic drives of the user, in a way they almost feel intrinsic, and they are **integrated** into the core values of the player. I have both borrowed and redefined these terms from the OIT, as my intention as a designer is to be able to understand if the goal and the feedback system is both *valuable for the activity and for the user*.

To understand this better let's go to the extrinsic extreme, what we will call *regulatory* goals. Imagine I tell you that for each 100 points you get in the game, you get 1 dollar to redeem for a coffee shop. This has been tried in the gaming industry, is not a revolutionary idea and has not worked at all! *Regulatory goals design are misaligned with their activity* and the drive to perform it, they become work! Playing a game and buying coffee from a coffee shop are unrelated activities, which means that if your **focus** becomes getting the coffee, you will stop enjoying the game itself. In this scenario you don't want the points to make your game experience better, but to use them *outside* the game, they are a job to be done, an obstacle to get to what you really want.

Let's sum this up to see if we can get the distinction right, while grounding this outside of games:

Type	In games	In real life
Intrinsic The goal is driven by inner needs and is not pushed from the outside	Defeating bosses in Final Fantasy is challenging and fun, so you try to beat them even the ones that are not required to complete the game.	You decide to change the organization's filing system to reduce inefficiencies and waste.
Regulatory The goal is pushed from outside and is misaligned with the activity you are performing	If you defeat all the bosses in a Final Fantasy, you are invited to apply for a scholarship in a prestigious school.	If you manage to organize the filing system, you get more time to do sports in the gym and get bonus money.
Introjected The goal is external by nature, but is aligned with the activity and its core drive.	If you defeat all the bosses in Final Fantasy you can access a FF community that makes modded bosses and tournaments.	If you manage to organize the filing system, you get a dashboard that allows you to measure the new efficiency of the company.

There is nothing forbidden in design

While in the origins of BEM the rule was to avoid regulatory goals, now I think you can use every tool in the toolbox if you understand how. Every kind of motivation has its ups and down.

Intrinsic goals are great to move performance and arousal, and lead to better work quality, but have pitfalls:

1. They are hard to design and require high degrees of personalization. You can't think that a person likes to read, but that they like to read gothic novels with strong female characters with a European setting after 9pm. Your designs might only move a small set of people if not.
2. They don't necessarily promote action. Some people can just daydream about what they'd wish to accomplish, but never put in the effort, because external pressure becomes more important in their daily life.
3. They require the user to make choices that sometimes are not aligned with the purpose of the system, or even oppose the system's will. Hacking a system is driven by internal drives.

Regulatory goals on the other hand are great to create short term attraction and initiate behavior when the activity itself is hard to make fun. But you have to be careful with every secondary effect they can bring to the table. Some of them are:

1. They change the focus of attention and value towards the prize, which makes the main activity seem less valuable. If you take the prize away, people will stop doing the activity, even if they liked doing it beforehand.
2. They lose value overtime. You gave a free meal? Now that's not interesting enough. You gave a free trip? Now you want to go somewhere more exotic. Like with your salary, the excitement of these regulatory goals is short lived and their ability to *reward* the receiver are diminished overtime.
3. They incentivize optimization versus quality. If there is a quicker, more efficient way to get to the prize, why not do it? Cheating becomes an option if the prize is too coveted and hard to get.

Introjected are the most recommended design choice in BEM, but they required some serious creativity. You are reframing an activity through its interfaces, through its secondary goals to make the *activity more appealing*. This is *the* hard choice, but the most powerful one if done right. Its pitfalls are:

1. It's easy to fall back to regulatory systems when something doesn't work, and is hard to notice when that happens.
2. They need to improve the experience of the activity somehow, or they can be easily ignored.

3. They might be designed over false inner drives or bring pains that were not present when there was less information on the system. Maybe giving a dashboard of efficiency for organizing the file systems only shows you that your file system is not doing any better than the previous one.

There is no magical formula, and testing is required to get it right, but the right answer is someplace where you are using all types of goals in your design. For example, you might use an extrinsic goal to initiate your user in a new activity, but then you are using introjected goals to show them why they should stick to it. Finally, you might incorporate some space for user exploration through arbitrary and emergent goals, to boost intrinsic drives.

Throughout this book you will see more concrete techniques of design, and keep in mind that rewiring your brain to think in this way will not be easy at first, but who wants easy? Well, most people, but BEM is for the 1% that wants to do this like a pro!

Finally, the GFR Framework

You have now some building blocks to start designing, but how do you tackle your design process?

As you can see, the *reward* is the goal. You want, at all costs, to activate that reward system to reinforce behaviors and learning. This means that you first need to define the needs you are going to be satisfying for you “players”. Those needs will mean understanding the basic human drives.

Once you have a clear motivational map that takes into account the game your users are already playing, you can start thinking how to nudge new drives or reinforce current ones, using goal and feedback design. What you are aiming for is the following:

1. **Goals** should create anticipation and attraction: you are selling your goals by making them seem feasible and interesting. But you have to be careful that you are not being over-reliant on regulatory deferred goals. You can use mechanics to make them more interesting, but remember, the key is micro-goaling and designing for diversity. Goal completion should activate more goals to keep the cycle going.
2. **Feedback** should inform the user of new goals and progress on current ones, using emotional language to keep engagement. Your feedback systems will have to support the biggest burden, because,
3. **Feedback** should trigger **reward responses** that reinforce anticipation of future goals. In BEM design it is the responsibility of your feedback systems to maintain drive.

To be able to accomplish this you need to have a good way to talk about those rewards and a good way to measure if the cycle is working. That's why we have our 7 driver framework, a powerful way to organize your design process, and even your theoretical background!

The 7 BEM Intrinsic Drivers

There is a weird fascination with the alchemic geometries of the sages of Faer. These figures would show interlocking nodes of power, and synergic principles. Some speculate they are the basis of our modern day magicks.

- *Big Book of Strange Symbols, tome 2.*

As I learned from Deci and Ryan the intricacies on human motivation, I could see the power of working with a taxonomy of **drivers** to think about **rewards**. It was elegant: it could bring down the whole complexity of human interactions and behaviors into a simple **3 driver** scheme. The division of human needs into *competence, autonomy and relatedness* was really clever and could help explain many of our needs and pains. If you don't know what I'm talking about, let's make a simple breakdown:

Competence	Autonomy	Relatedness
The need for self-efficacy, of being able to achieve goals by having enough mastery.	The need for self-direction, of being able to make choices and feel empowered by them	Our need for social-bonds, for being connected with others and feeling social security.

Then I read Daniel Pink, and he left out relatedness in favor of purpose, the need for a *reason or a higher calling*. It was interesting, as Edward Deci thought of purpose as a part of autonomy, but this division ended up on what Marczewski calls RAMP: *relatedness, autonomy, mastery and purpose*. This subdivision proved to me to be useful, as it helped see further dimensions of human motivation.

But now I will instead lead you through my rationale to take these 4 drivers and further divide them into 7.

Using drivers as a core organizational scheme in Gamification was not new when I designed BEM: Octalysis is built over 8 core drives and only four of them, the white hat drives, are based on RAMP (Epic Meaning & Calling, Development & Accomplishment, Empowerment of Creativity & Feedback, and Social Influence & Relatedness). Octalysis had a heavy influence on me, as it showed me that maybe the RAMP model was incomplete. Again, this division was elegant and could help make useful subdivisions in more than just the types of mechanics and feedback used on a project.

Hexad's user types were also a great inspiration, and he also had a catalogue based on these four drivers. His model was an elaboration of Richard Bartle's player types, and he included the intrinsic and extrinsic aspect for each driver, which I think is brilliant. In this sense, he has the Free Spirit as a manifestation of autonomy, the Achiever as driven by mastery, the Socializer as moved by Relatedness and the Philanthropist as motivated by purpose. His model has been updated a lot since that time and I encourage you to find more about it.

Both those frameworks add some additional dimensions, like the Player and Disruptor in Hexad's, and the 4 black hat drives in Octalysis, as, I think, they also felt that SDTs base drivers were probably just not enough to explain the complexity of the player experience. What would Deci and Ryan think of these approaches, I wonder. I'm no expert on those frameworks, I follow them and have read the authors (mainly their blogs and excerpts from their books), I must admit, as I am more driven by analyzing and designing, than by just implementing other methods, but these core principles were inspiring to me, and broke with what was being done with the more *toolkit of game elements* approach. So, any similarities are probably not a coincidence, but I hope the reader-disciple of this book will find that behind that surface, the three frameworks have different flavors and can learn from all of them.

The first thing I wanted to make sure was that my framework would be organized by psychogenic needs based on intrinsic drivers alone. I took the intrinsic vs extrinsic part of the equation out of the scheme, of course, as you have to remember that for a BEM disciple, *rewards are always intrinsic*, and it's the misalignment that causes extrinsicity. Hexad is more a model of how some people are more moved by extrinsic goals and other from intrinsic ones, but mine is about *introjections*, so I needed to keep the driver model pure.

Thus, I parted from the 4 SDT drivers and started analyzing them from the perspective of game design user-system relations. The first thing I was clear about was that the driver of *autonomy* was just too complex still, even if you gave *purpose* its own definition. In the gaming world there's a usual division of games of chance and games of skill, which not only defines the game structure but actually a type of player. Although games of skill could

be understood simply as games of *mastery or competence*, I found that it was not only about being competent in the game, it was about having or not a sense of *control*.

Autonomy, the need for self direction, and heteronomy, the need for outer control, are two sides of the same coin: it's the relationship you have with **uncertainty**. As a game designer I'm trained to think this way, because every game is an uncertainty engine that is resolved when it's over. And while some people are more driven by the desire of exploration, creativity and risk, the realm of the uncertain, other people prefer the realm of dominion, power and control, the realm of the certain. The first type of need, rooted in games of chance and exploration, I called it *Discovery and Creativity*, the other, rooted in games of competitions and strategy, I called it *Empowerment and Control*.

Then, I realized that some types of games, especially board games, which I'm really fond of, were about *optimization*. Farming behaviors appeared a lot in games, even though they would not lead to mastery, just hoarding. I realized many of our biases explained by behavioral economists are a product of a certain impatience that appears when we are managing resources. I thought at the moment, this was also about empowerment, but it was so different from other *empowering* behaviors, that I decided it should have its own category: the need for *efficiency and productivity*. If you think about it, most of our efficiency-related behaviors are not about autonomy in its core: we actually have heuristics to manage our resources that disempower us and take choices out of the table. And it became a driver on its own, the one rooted in behavioral economics to a degree.

Finally, SDT had an important flaw for me: it ignored all the theories built around *aesthetics and hedonism*. Again, going to a museum was an act of autonomy, but the actual need was rooted in something more profound, our need for sensorial pleasure. Maybe it's because my whole career of literature was built upon understanding concepts of beauty, structure, rhythm and the such that this was really important to me. Hedonism is not just a need, but a powerful attractor and a means of judgement, the thing that might nudge many of your choices in favor of things that go easy on the eye: we just can't turn off our judgements based on appearances (something I learned from Kahneman, *the behavioral economist*).

This left me with a 7 driver model: purpose, discovery, empowerment, mastery, relatedness, efficiency and hedonism. Let's make a deeper dive into each one.

Hedonism & Aesthetic Pleasure

As the sun set in the horizon of the pixelated sky, Walt contemplated the beauty in sight. It was a graveyard of soldiers and dragons, of dismembered bodies and blood. He pressed hard on his necromancy staff and started an incantation he called "The beauty in death".

The defeat of the allied forces of Halan, analysts of the Dark Era.

Have you ever felt awe in the face of overwhelming beauty? Well, beauty is a complex concept that has been researched by the field of aesthetics. We know symmetric faces create that sense of beauty, but we also know Baudelaire created beauty out of putrefaction. *Flowers of evil* is a book that uses disgust as a motor for aesthetic pleasure, by using synesthesia and defamiliarization.

Every sense has the power of aesthetic pleasure, disgust or homeostasis. Feeling dizzy, hot, pressured, disgusted can create powerful needs for action. You might feel like going to the doctor, or opening some windows, or moving something heavy away from you, or stopping those horrible noises kids nowadays call music! You open your freezer and can't find something appealing to eat? Well, it is not just about surviving, so you might prefer getting some ingredients or spending more money to get something tasty.

And hedonism is not a single-sensory experience. You can't divide what you see from what you hear or smell. Mute the sound of a movie, and beautiful photography will not be enough to keep you engaged. The museum smells funny? That can kill the joy of the visual pleasure. Your senses work in tandem, and there are several properties being taken and analyzed by your brain: is the animation going too fast? Is the sound too loud or too pitchy? Is the climate too dry? Is your mouth tasting funny? Everything is creating an experience that might be not ideal enough, and then, you will spend energy towards finding pleasure or homeostasis. Maybe you will drink a delicious cup of wine (pleasure), maybe you will adjust the temperature to a comfortable state (homeostasis).

Games are an art form, with great budgets destined to satisfy our hedonic drives. Have you ever played *Journey*? Have you seen the world of *Horizon Dawn*? Have you seen the art of the board game *Mysterium* or *Dixit*? Hedonism is not just a way for creating experience, but actually a way to attract players into the game and create a positive mood towards them. Check the cover of *God of War IV*, and see how it drives your curiosity. The whole interface design of modern video games has some careful thoughts on how to create aesthetic pleasure. Check the inner menus of *The Rise of The Tomb Raider*: everything from the graphic design, to the use of perspective and sound effects is calculated to maximize pleasure.

So never give for granted the power of Hedonism, especially in the corporate world or academia, where it's most often forgotten. We now live in a world of templates and standardized design principles, and we are numbing ourselves to the pleasure of really beautiful interfaces, especially when an entrepreneur is releasing an MVP. LMS are, for the most part, horrible administrative interfaces that give little joy to anybody, and progress bars, when used, appear static, without glows, animations or other artifacts to impact the experience.

Avoidance: the need to avoid displeasure and discomfort on our senses

Approach: the need to seek pleasurable stimuli and experiences that awe are senses

Efficiency & Economic Productivity

The King looked down at his Keeper of Gold and Tax. The chambers of wealth were almost empty, as the King's pleasures were getting out of hand. "My liege, we need to cut on banquets and damsels, or your people will rebel". The King said, "out of my sight!". The next thing the King felt was the dagger in his chest: "You will not kill your people, we will cut the root of the problem".

Book of Treachery, chapter III, On how Treachery saved the Kingdom of Ililan.

Our brains are efficiency-driven "machines". They prefer methods of quick calculation and decision making, in opposition to slow ways of thinking, as they consume more energy. Resource management is a big thing for our brains, and we have evolved to be optimizers. And the most important resource is time.

There is a whole bias called *Loss Aversion* which has now become increasingly popular, as it explains that we overreact to losses, in contrast with our less emotional reactions to gains. And time is something you can only lose, which gives way to phrases like "you are losing your time" or "stop wasting your time!". Games were treated in the past as time wasters, driven by hedonic pleasures, and thought in opposition to work, a highly efficient way of spending your time, as it was a productive activity. But players' brains were treating games as highly productive systems, as they come with all sorts of resource optimization mechanics, like with *Age of Empires* or *Minecraft*. Players would work for their games in ways that were unexpected, trying to get the most out of them in the least amount of time.

One of the main characteristics of games is their *time dilution effect*, which is found in movies and other narrative media as well. As our lives transit so slowly, games have the opportunity to fast-forward the boring parts, and make ages happen in hours. And for a player, these hours felt like minutes! In games, wars are won in 50+ hours of gameplay, army battles could take 2 hours or so, and healing from an injury would be a matter of seconds. The characters never tire down, so they can keep running through the world to reach faster distant areas, and, if you are a high-level character, just a movement of your wand and you would be in remote lands in the time it took the game to load.

Competition also enables efficiency, as scarcity creates a need for optimization. When you are playing against another team, you need to score faster, which leads to maximizing strategies that increase your chances to score, while thinking of other strategies to hinder

the other team's possibilities of reaching the goal. Board gamers are optimizers, with every action being so unique and scarce that you cannot make random choices, you need a level of calculation not used on other types of games: avoiding computation and trial and error is less efficient than overthinking your move!

Urgency is the driver of many of our human actions, and methodologies of design are built for reducing the pain of doing long research on a topic before doing an innovation. We prefer low calculated innovations that can be rolled out fast, to long research methods that, we feel, might be obsolete when the time to launch a product has come: we prefer to risk money over time. We measure everything by time and opportunity: discounts, freebies, estimated times of arrival, even the floor number in an elevator is reducing efficiency related pains, even though it's only a progress bar towards your destination. And that is why many farming mechanics in game design work in the short term, as they become the shortest path to get something we value.

What is AI if not a tool for efficiency? Can we now make hard tasks happen in seconds? Can I redirect my efforts to more creative and engaging tasks instead of having to type keys on my computer?

The power of the Efficiency driver to move behavior is strong, but it's also full of dangers, as we need to be sure what our players will be optimizing, because cheating is about optimization as well. So, beware of this driver, as it can improve or kill your Gamification project without giving you any notice.

Avoidance: the need to avoid the loss of resources and the pain of feeling unproductive

Approach: the desire of increasing our outcomes by reducing our efforts, of finding better strategies to manage our resources.

Relatedness & Empathy

The path that Linda, the Druid, had chosen with her white wolf Lana, was lonely. The woods were all they could see every day, until the day King Alber's caravan appeared. "We could take you back to the kingdom, if you wish", a guard said, after seeing that loneliness in her eyes. An hour later, Linda was sharing a meal with Lana, stolen from the death guards of Jael and their Caravan. She petted her wolf and said: "You are all I need".

The Big Hunt for the Lone Druid, For the People of Jael.

This is one of the main SDT drivers, and the one connected with pro-sociality, empathy, trustfulness, belonging and so on. In games, this driver is really interesting, because it leads to all kinds of design choices, some of which might feel counterintuitive. Let's break this down with examples.

In 1996 Aki Maita released the Tamagotchi. It was a weird game with no clear goal, but to keep a virtual character alive. If you are a cat person you should know that one of the main appeals of those furry friends is that they need almost no care at all, not compared with dogs or, even worse, human beings! But humans are still driven by nurture, and this was the basis of the success of a little device that, if you didn't take good care of it, it would die in your hands! Relatedness is not just about empathizing with organic beings, it can be transferred to all sorts of things, and video games can simulate all kinds of expressions and cuteness. So, it's not a big surprise that the Tamagotchi came from the land of *Kawaii*, the country where everything can be *cute* and relatable.

But relatedness can explain other weird behaviors. If you've ever played *Monopoly* (and chances are you have!), that game is about individualistic goals, is about crushing your opponents in relentless ways. Still, if you ever wonder why that game takes so long to finish, part of the reason comes from the fact that player elimination (something modern board games avoid to use) creates social pain. It wasn't rare to see a player in the brink of bankruptcy and another player cheating the game giving her some money as a loan to keep her in the game. Most of the family fights you might have experienced playing that game were because competitive types would do things that would crush that spirit of human empathy. Playing *Monopoly* efficiently means having no empathy for the other players, something most of us are unable to do, so we sacrifice a good move for a good relationship.

It is not a secret that when couples play together there is always a chance of weird gaming behaviors. Sometimes they don't attack each other even if there is a clear strategic advantage, sometimes they fight over irrelevant things. Human relatedness requires that the game have some clear social rules, and some martial arts have some rituals of respect towards the opponent, like bowing, to help them remember that it is not just about winning at all costs. But, if this can happen in this atomic way, when there are just a couple of people involved, what could happen in a massive online environment?

Toxic players are everywhere, from trolls to griefers, and a sense of anonymity can create serious problems in terms of social bonds. Still, this is not the norm in most multiplayer games, we tend to be more pro-social gamers as a species. But some games can just take out the worst of us. Think of *League of Legends*, which was famous for its rude community, and its attempt to filter out asocial behaviors. Or dare to play *Diplomacy*, a board game designed to bring the worst in people by inviting treachery. Games like *Clash Royale* actually design limited communication systems that only allow you to express yourselves through established emotes. That's because designers know they must take care of their communities. Yes, games allow a level of trolling, as it can be fun to dance over your friend's corpse now and then, but they take care that social norms are kept and moderators are everywhere. A loss in the pro-social experience in your game might mean a loss of players as well.

What you have to take into account is that this driver moderates all things related to the possible social interactions, so that the social experience is optimized. But it also deals with character creation and creating bonds of trust. It doesn't matter if you are building single player campaigns or multiplayer systems, you need to always take this driver into account.

Avoidance: the need to avoid awkward or unwanted social interactions, as well as the need to avoid states of loneliness.

Approach: the desire of building social connections and bonds with others, or other things.

Mastery & Progress

Keit of Kirth was winning the Chuco-riding race. Only the big leap was left and a final straight. He increased the speed to jump over the cannon with his chuco and prepared for the jump. In midair, he did something weird, he stood up on his saddle and jumped, spreading his legs in an acrobatic move. When the Chuco touched the ground, they lost balance and fell, breaking their legs. The race was lost.

Kirth's anal of Chuco Racing, Third edition.

SDT calls this the driver of Competence, but Daniel Pink made it famous in his book *Drive* by calling it "Mastery". Now, both "competence" and "mastery" can be misleading labels, as the first might seem close to competition, and the second one as a status of expertise. I called it "Mastery & Progress", because this is a dynamic driver, based on training and learning, and a sense of self fulfilment when goals and challenges are finally met.

What I mean with this is that Mastery is really about how the challenge moves us or makes us run away, and how we seek harder challenges or prefer to be in a comfort zone. By nature, every game is built around challenges, big and small, always driven by this architecture of goals, milestones, checkpoints and performance feedback. The challenge is the main driver of action, but also the main driver of avoidance. Some challenges might feel too dull (like many secondary missions in some MMORPGs where you need to take an object and give it to someone else), and others might feel too hard, like getting a decent score on *Flappy Bird* or surviving in *Dark Souls*.

How many challenges can be created with a controller and a screen? It seems endless, as precision-based challenges can take you to many gaming worlds. How many challenges can be created with boards, cards and pieces? It seems endless, as each new combination of rules and elements create different problems. But sometimes we find gamification challenges in the form of "Buy 3 things in my store" or "make 10 phone calls" or "log 3

times to the LMS". These are tasks, not challenges, and will not activate a sense of accomplishment or mastery. Game Designers create interesting systems that can be *played with*, that can be solved using different strategies, and that create conflict.

This driver will take so much space in this book that I don't want to over explain it here, but make no mistake, the way you design for mastery will have a huge impact on your probabilities of success with your gamification project. And always remember that mastery is a path to improvement, not a state of knowledge and skill.

Avoidance: the need to avoid tasks and challenges that make you feel incompetent or stagnated

Approach: the drive to tackle, with self-efficacy and self-reliance, hard problems and challenges

Discovery & Creativity

When Yami opened the forgotten chest, she knew the whole people of Lyotar would be enlightened by its contents. Several tomes of knowledge from the arcane days would teach their people about electricity and other mysterious phenomena. She browsed tome after tome, and scroll after scroll, until she found a curious one. It was red and massive, with metal ornaments. Only three words on the cover: Do not Read! She was brave and opened the tome and then...

Incomplete tale of Yami, from the folk tales of old.

Uncertainty... we have built in ourselves a curious brain that needs completion, that needs to have closure, but that thrives in the road of mystery that leads towards that end. Great stories and great works of art are driven by this impulse to tap into the unknown and resolve it. Great researchers that want to push the boundaries of the unknown because knowing the question, but not having the answer is just too painful!

What is dark matter? What secrets lie behind Stonehenge? What's inside Area 51? Is the Bermuda Triangle really a thing? What happens when we die? What does the girl or boy you have a crush on think of you? Incompleteness and uncertainty lie everywhere we look, and we are the only species in this world actually being able to ask questions to each other and find ways to get difficult answers.

Games thrive on the thrill of discovery and creation, using every psychological hook to keep us engaged. Great storylines keep you interested in pushing forward through the next level, locked content will keep you looking for the key, drum rolls or dice rolls increase expectation as an outcome will be resolved, randomness creates a sense of

unpredictability that might make you play against all odds. But, also, you have the ability to customize, to create, to build and design many features of your game world.

Knowing how to tackle discovery in your designs can be the difference between a horrible tutorial and a real onboarding experience. We are drawn towards great mysteries, and that's why we love detective genres, or suspense movies, or a great plot twist. Games begin with an exposition that, more often than not, creates questions to be answered. It might be a cutscene when you press play, where they tell you that a kingdom of old was destroyed by a mysterious event, and now all the titans are asleep, but one has awakened! Your brain will automatically start making questions: what destroyed that kingdom? What made the titans go to sleep? Why is this one awakening now? These answers will be answered at a pace, you need to *delay gratification* when dealing with discovery: expectancy is key.

You know, curiosity killed the cat, but it also took us to the moon (unless you think it's a hoax, which means you have even more questions than answers, because conspiracy theories are moved by this driver). Discovery has innate risks, the unknown is full of dangers, but, by the same logic, full of adventures. In games you can explore all those dangers, without actually being in danger yourself. It optimizes discovery in a way only few other things do, like narrative media, social media and travel, for example.

Content—and how you present it—is king! The form is the content, as a certain school of Russian literature theory would tell you. Schools have all the content they need to keep students engaged, but the way they present it makes no sense, it brings no thrill. It is a design problem, and gamification can help you tackle that very issue. And this applies to products and services as well. Knowing how to leverage discovery is one of the most powerful techniques you can learn as a gamification designer. Want to know how to do it? Everything in due time...

Avoidance: The pain of the routine, of being able to know what will happen, of having to always do things always in the same way.

Approach: The desire of taking risks, of playing with uncertainty

Empowerment & Control

For 100 years the struggle between the Rayfs, the Helgors and the Buitongs kept the people of Moldan in a state of panic. Rayfs controlled the commerce, Helgors the militia and Buitongs the magicks. But neither controlled the people. Maybe the war that was brewing would resolve this tension, or maybe it would bring destruction. Only time would tell.

The fall of Moldan and the three houses of Power. Written by the sage of knowledge.

Certainly, from Plato to Foucault, philosophers and thinkers have been wondering about the struggles of power. Why such a heavily social species thrives so much in violence and war, on dominance and hierarchies? There is something in our very nature that competes with our empathetic nature, and that loves conflict in the form of competition.

Empowerment is based on our need of control, in our need to be able to predict and modify outcomes, on having ownership and being able to enforce our rules. Having so much we can't actually control, we focus on what we can, like our house rules, or our choices in our daily lives. For most of us, this sense of control is in flux and competition, as we usually live with other people in the same space that don't care for the same things we do, or that care too much for things we feel are not important. We are comparing and competing by nature, and so, having a perfectly cooperative society becomes impossible.

Sporting games were designed to avoid wars in a time of conflict, because games have a superpower: they create conflict without consequence. Losing a javelin throwing contest would mean dishonor, but not dead. Of course, there are exceptions to these rules, like the sacrificial ritual around the game of the ball the Aztecs played, and you could theorize that in a dystopian society something like the Hunger Games could appear. But the games we are dealing with today are about optimizing this need for power, by creating a balanced system that feels fair, but empowering nonetheless.

In games, power is in constant flux, so you can get it, but you might lose it. You are never an all-powerful being, but developing your skills can help you nudge the odds in your favor. Playing *UNO*, having a +4 card is really empowering, but you spend it after you lose it, disempowering you for the following rounds. Your bullets in your best weapons are scarce in shooter games, and you can only get the best power ups in *Mario Kart* if you are in the last positions. The balance of power and skill is one of the main things a game designer has to deal with, and knowing that the wrong design can make your players hate each other gives you a lot of responsibility. So I hope the tools in this book will empower you in your designs, we know we all need this.

Avoidance: the pain of not having control or influence on things you care or that feel dangerous

Approach: the need to take actions that make you feel more in control, that gives you certainty.

Epic Identity & Purpose

The rope pressed hard against her neck. All she could think about was how unfair her situation was. Why was she hanging there, struggling to get air in her lungs, when it was

Weyford the one changing all the policies of the realm. At least she died for a cause she believed in...

The fall of the tyrannical reign of the Red Dame, scroll XI

Our brains are built to give value to the things we experience in the world, but nothing creates more emotional states than ideologies. Culture is a set of discursive ideas that try to bring sense and order to the world, and tradition are the rituals and thoughts that give shape to that culture. Ethics, morality, religion, political parties, soccer teams, and rock stars have this in common, the creation of values that help us build identity on the individual and cultural level.

Games tend to throw the word “mission” around a lot, but not everything in a game is an actual mission. While challenges or pleasurable activities can have goals, missions are built around purpose and value, which gives them long term importance. Even rooting for a baseball team can become Epic for the human brain, and many cultural tribes spend hours, money and energy going beyond logic to show support to their teams. They can even shape counter cultural behaviors, as they promote ways to distance from the “establishment”: tribal structures form from shared identities that transcend challenges or simple social goals.

Epic Identity, in a sense, is not built from designing a challenge, but by creating a narrative and discursive space, with a clear cause that transcends the individual. Let’s save a forest, let’s save a dog, let’s stop corruption, let’s fight for our rights: all these missions are not measured by the individual achievements, but by understanding the state of the cause. The game is to plant more trees, even if you are not the one to plant them, or support a dog shelter, even if you don’t have a dog.

This is probably the most powerful driver, but also the most difficult to shape if you are working with a broad audience. In a niche project the narrative is easy to accommodate to the individuals, but in bigger projects you need to recur to archetypes, to big ideas shared by many people: saving the world from an evil being, keeping a society safe, finding a cure for a lethal disease, finding your soulmate. The designer has to read the cultural values, but also understand that beneath any activity a higher purpose can be achieved: the problem is making the player feel like it is really a higher purpose. Storytelling can be the biggest asset for this driver, and a great narrative can impact motivation more than you can even imagine. So never forget that ideas become energy and motivation in a big way!

Avoidance: the pain of finding opposing values and ideologies. Having to act against your own moral compass or against the things you believe in

Approach: the need to progress missions around causes, of spreading ideas and saving the world

Let's create a quick summary table for the seven drivers, that you can use for future reference:

Hedonism & Aesthetic Pleasure	This driver focuses on the emotional and sensory experience of a gameful system. It includes visual aesthetics, sound design, and the overall pleasure derived from interacting with a well-designed system. The goal is to make the experience enjoyable, immersive, and emotionally engaging, which goes beyond functionality.
Efficiency & Economic Productivity	This driver is about optimization and resource management. People are naturally inclined to seek the most efficient way to achieve their goals. Gamification can leverage this by creating systems that feel productive, minimize wasted effort, and provide clear value while avoiding burnout or farming mechanics.
Relatedness & Empathy	Humans are social creatures, and this driver centers on fostering meaningful social connections. It includes cooperation, competition, trust, and community building. Strong social mechanics can enhance engagement by making players feel part of a group, whether through teamwork, friendly rivalry, or shared achievements.
Mastery & Progress	This driver taps into the human need to improve skills and achieve goals. Learning loops, feedback mechanisms, and balanced difficulty curves all play a role in keeping players engaged. A sense of progress—through leveling up, acquiring new abilities, or overcoming challenges—fuels long-term motivation.
Discovery & Creativity	Curiosity is a powerful motivator. This driver encourages exploration, experimentation, and problem-solving. It plays a crucial role in onboarding, learning new mechanics, and maintaining engagement through novelty and

	surprise. Failure is also an integral part of discovery, as it leads to deeper learning and iteration.
Empowerment & Control	This driver is about autonomy, decision-making, and the ability to influence the system. Players need to feel that their choices matter, whether in customization, strategy, or navigating challenges. It also includes the dynamics of power, influence, and the risks of manipulation or toxic behavior.
Epic Identity & Purpose	The highest-level driver, this taps into meaning and long-term engagement. People seek narratives, values, and causes that resonate with their personal identity. When players feel they are part of something greater than themselves—whether a grand story, a moral cause, or a long-term goal—they are deeply motivated to engage.

Closing the Cycle: there are no games without loops

TBD

You are now Disciple of BEM

You have read the foundations of the BEM framework, a way of seeing the world that has allowed me to win 4 Gamicon/TechLearn awards, two of them were *Best Overall Use of Gamification*. But as you can see, all these principles are just a roadmap, not a true method.

Not only that, but they will require that you experiment a lot and create your design style. The disciple of BEM knows there is power in games, but is also aware that not every game is a hit, and designing top games requires effort. The disciple will never stop being a disciple, and until today, after 13 years of working in Gamification, I'm still learning and incorporating new ideas into my designs.

But this book will try to give you more context into how to design goals, feedback systems and loops for each kind of player, to get you started into your own experimental designs. As you will see, each driver has a lot of nuance, and integrating everything into one design will require effort. But the good news is that you don't have to know everything to start making experiments.

Just by reading this first chapter you are ready to go into the real world and try things. You can even download this first chapter as a PDF and feed it to an AI to help you think about how to tackle your problems. Design masters become masters by designing, so start thinking on how to apply this knowledge.

But for in depth techniques, just continue reading!

PART II: THE PATH OF DESIGN

TBD

From Drivers to Designable Archetypes

The seven BEM drivers provide the designer, or disciple of BEM, with a foundational structure for crafting goal architectures that engage different play or use styles. By understanding these drivers, a designer can define the type of experience they want to create—what LeBlanc refers to as Aesthetics in his MDA Framework. Is the design primarily about challenge (Mastery) or community (Relatedness)?

However, not all users motivated by the same driver will exhibit identical behaviors. Within each driver, we can further classify user tendencies into "archetypes," which help refine the engagement strategy for different player personas. These archetypes emerge in the design process based on the specific **context** and **audience**, making them valuable tools for customization and deeper engagement.

The way I achieve this can be by analyzing current emergent goal-oriented behavior patterns in a system, or imagine new patterns that have not been thought of, to create experiments. To make this a reality, the BEM way means creating general descriptors that can then be made into a hypothesis to be tested. Let's see some examples of archetypes so you can imagine how to think of your own designs.

Hedonism

Within the Hedonism driver, archetypes should be focused on properties like composition, aesthetic value, comfort, and so on, which means you can imagine the following kinds of users being archetypes of this driver.

Composer: The Composer thrives on arranging and structuring elements into cohesive and aesthetically pleasing compositions. This archetype is often found in music production, graphic design, and user interface customization. For example, a player in a sandbox game like Minecraft may spend hours meticulously designing elaborate structures, ensuring symmetry, color balance, and thematic coherence. Similarly, a Composer using a productivity app may enjoy customizing dashboards, creating aesthetically pleasing layouts, and adjusting fonts and colors to enhance usability.

Cleaner: The Cleaner experiences deep satisfaction from tidying up and removing unnecessary elements, streamlining an experience for optimal clarity. This archetype often appears in digital environments where organization is key, such as email inbox management, file organization, or cleaning up cluttered interfaces. A Cleaner might be drawn to apps like Unroll.Me to declutter emails or spend time in a game like Animal Crossing arranging their town in a visually appealing and functional manner. In productivity tools, they might habitually clear notifications, close redundant tabs, and ensure that only essential information is visible, maintaining a sense of order and control.

Efficiency

Within the Efficiency driver, archetypes focus on resource management, optimization, and effectiveness. Users influenced by this driver are drawn to maximizing productivity and minimizing waste and you can use these attributes to build archetypes like the following:

Manager: The Manager enjoys structuring, distributing, and optimizing resources within complex systems to maintain productivity. This archetype thrives in environments where strategic allocation is key, such as in real-time strategy games like Age of Empires, where efficient resource management determines success. In workplace productivity tools, a Manager might focus on optimizing workflows, ensuring the best use of time and manpower, and prioritizing automation to reduce inefficiencies.

Spender: The Spender seeks to acquire resources quickly and utilize them as soon as possible, often engaging in trade or immediate consumption. This archetype appears in real-time strategy games like Age of Empires, where players focus on quick asset turnover for short-term gains. In digital marketplaces, Spenders may prefer dynamic pricing models, often making impulsive purchases to stay ahead, and accrue virtual currencies that can only be used for redemption.

Mastery

Mastery archetypes focus on challenge, skill-building, and strategic problem-solving. Users driven by this element aim for personal excellence and system mastery, which can be turned into archetype like:

Achiever: The Achiever aims to complete all objectives with the highest scores and perfect execution. This archetype thrives in goal-oriented environments like Dark Souls, where mastery of mechanics is essential. In gamified learning platforms, Achievers pursue certifications, accumulating badges and completing courses at an accelerated pace to demonstrate expertise, and prefer contents with performance rating that can be replayed for optimal scoring.

Hacker: The Hacker explores system loopholes and unconventional paths to achieve success. Unlike Achievers, who follow structured paths, Hackers prefer to break and manipulate game rules, much like speedrunners exploiting game mechanics in Super

Mario Bros. In business settings, Hackers might find unorthodox ways to streamline workflows, bypassing unnecessary steps for efficiency, or find ways to avoid using predefined processes.

Relatedness

Relatedness archetypes center around social interaction, cooperation, and emotional connection within systems. There can be a myriad of social-centered archetypes and the following are just a small sample of behavior patterns:

Team Player: The Team Player prioritizes group success over individual achievements, working collaboratively toward shared objectives. Found in cooperative games like Overwatch, Team Players focus on synergy and coordination. In corporate settings, they enhance teamwork by fostering communication, improving collaboration tools, and promoting a collective success mindset.

Nurturer: The Nurturer ensures that others have the best possible experience, acting as a supportive force within a community. In games like The Sims, Nurturers enjoy taking care of in-game characters. In online communities, they moderate discussions, provide mentorship, and guide new users, ensuring an inclusive and welcoming environment.

Discovery

The Discovery driver fuels curiosity, exploration, and learning. Users driven by this element thrive on uncovering the unknown and experimenting with new ideas, which can lead to several user types within a system. The most prominent usually are:

Explorer: The Explorer thrives on uncovering hidden content, venturing beyond predefined boundaries to discover new experiences. Open-world games like The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild cater to this archetype by rewarding curiosity. In learning applications, Explorers might seek additional resources beyond structured courses, enjoying self-guided education, or might seek non-linear courses.

Experimenter: The Experimenter embraces trial and error, using feedback to refine strategies. Puzzle games like Portal encourage Experimenters to test creative solutions repeatedly. In workplaces, they innovate by trying new methodologies and testing prototypes, ensuring continuous improvement through iterative processes.

Empowerment

Empowerment archetypes are about control, influence, and competition, where users seek to exert their will over a system or others. As this driver might encompass many manifestations of power and control, finding the right patterns of design can be challenging. Some common ones are:

Competitor: The Competitor thrives in direct challenges against others, seeking validation through rankings, leaderboards, and measurable success. Competitive gaming in League of Legends appeals to this archetype, as does performance tracking in fitness apps where users compare progress against peers.

Climber: The Climber is driven by power-based progression, constantly striving to acquire tools, unlock new abilities, or expand their influence. In role-playing games like Skyrim, Climbers focus on leveling up skills and acquiring better gear. In career development, Climbers pursue promotions and continuous skill-building, always seeking the next opportunity for advancement.

Epic Identity

The Epic Identity driver is focused on long-term meaning, belief systems, and ideological motivations, which means that the archetypes based on this driver tend to be discursive in nature, centering on causes or moral compasses. Some examples can be:

Ideologist: The Ideologist navigates systems through a framework of strong beliefs, making decisions aligned with their values. In games like Deus Ex, players take ideological stances that affect story outcomes. In real-world applications, Ideologists advocate for sustainability, ethical practices, or political causes in their professional or personal lives.

Reactionary: The Reactionary opposes established norms, challenging dominant structures and pushing for disruptive change. Games like Cyberpunk 2077 cater to this archetype, allowing players to rebel against authority. In social movements, Reactionaries drive activism, questioning traditional policies and advocating for radical reform.

Applying Archetypes in the Design Process

These archetypes serve as a crucial layer in the design of gamified systems, helping designers craft meaningful goals that align with diverse user motivations. By considering archetypes, a designer can:

- Design goals and challenges that resonate with different user types.
- Reinforce behaviors by using the feedback mechanisms that better talk to the archetype
- Anticipate and shape emergent behaviors within the system.

By integrating both the seven BEM drivers and their corresponding archetypes into the design process, gamification can move beyond generic motivators and create systems that feel personally meaningful, immersive, and engaging for a diverse audience.

What is different in BEM to many other motivation-driven frameworks is that the list of archetypes is never complete. Actually, what other motivation frameworks call drivers, in

BEM they are *usually* archetypes within a driver. This means you can actually use other frameworks to drive inspiration and increase your personas.

Why do I leave it open? Remember, BEM is a discipline, not a set list of elements, so it can be expanded according to the needs of the project. In that sense, the Disciples of BEM must understand that any *adjective* can be transformed into a new archetype if you understand the patterns of goals that type of person seeks. What is important is that any archetype must be aligned with a driver to make the design process more streamlined when applying mechanics and feedback elements.

Let's map adjectives from other frameworks, like **Champfrogs, Octalysis, Bartles', Dr. Reiss' 16 desires or Nick Yee, PhD's** to the 7 core drivers, and try to see how they all have common principles that you can use within your designs.

Note: I'm not including the ones that I deem are not drivers or driver related, like "goal" in Champfrogs, or those that have the same name as the core driver. Some adjectives can be mapped into several drivers, like "order", but in each one they are talking about something different, like the aesthetic pleasure of finding order, or using order as a means for efficiency. I'm including some nouns, like Family, although I would not use them as archetypes.

Hedonism & Pleasure	Order Beauty Action (Yee's destruction and excitement) Immersion
Efficiency & Productivity	Scarcity & Impatience Loss & Avoidance Order Eating Physical Activity Savings
Mastery & Progress	Development & Accomplishment Achiever / Achievement Physical Activity Action
Relatedness & Empathy	Social Influence & Relatedness Socializer Acceptance Family Social Contract

Discovery & Creativity	Empowerment of Creativity & Feedback Unpredictability & Curiosity Explorer Curiosity Immersion
Empowerment & Control	Empowerment of Creativity & Feedback Ownership & Possession Killer Order Status Power Freedom Independence Tranquility Vengeance Action
Epic Identity & Purpose	Epic Meaning & Calling Honor Idealism Independence

It should not be a surprise to see relations between BEM and all of this frameworks, as many of them derive from Self Determination Theory, and this does not mean you can forget about all of those frameworks, as each have different design philosophies and can give you tools to improve your understanding of Gamification as a field.

But I do want to emphasize that using adjectives to create a list of drivers is not the best way to tackle the problem, as the list can become infinite. BEM can give you an organized framework to then think of the archetypes you want to design for, and use as many adjectives as you need to describe them, remembering that the core distinctions between drivers is still there.

Also, it is nice to note how humans tend to focus too much on Empowerment and Efficiency-based adjectives, while we tend to forget some really important ones, like Hedonism or Epic Identity. That may explain our over-reliance on money to drive behaviors in the corporate world, forgetting that the entertainment industry is huge and relies mainly on aesthetics to drive income.

Integrating the context: the starting point

TBD